

A woman with blonde hair, wearing a black corset, black gloves, and a black beaded necklace, posing against a dark, patterned background.

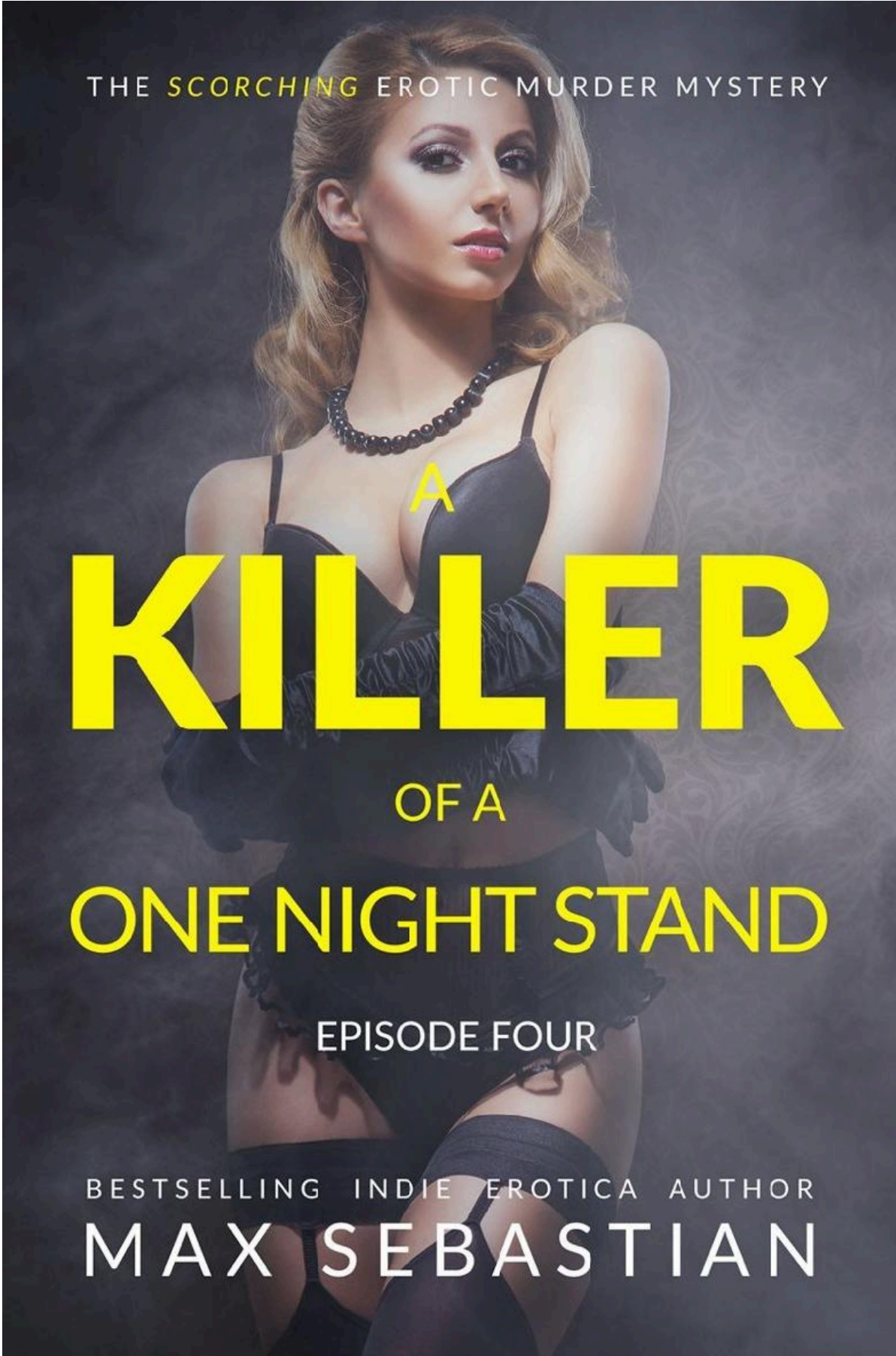
THE *SCORCHING* EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE FOUR

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

MAX SEBASTIAN

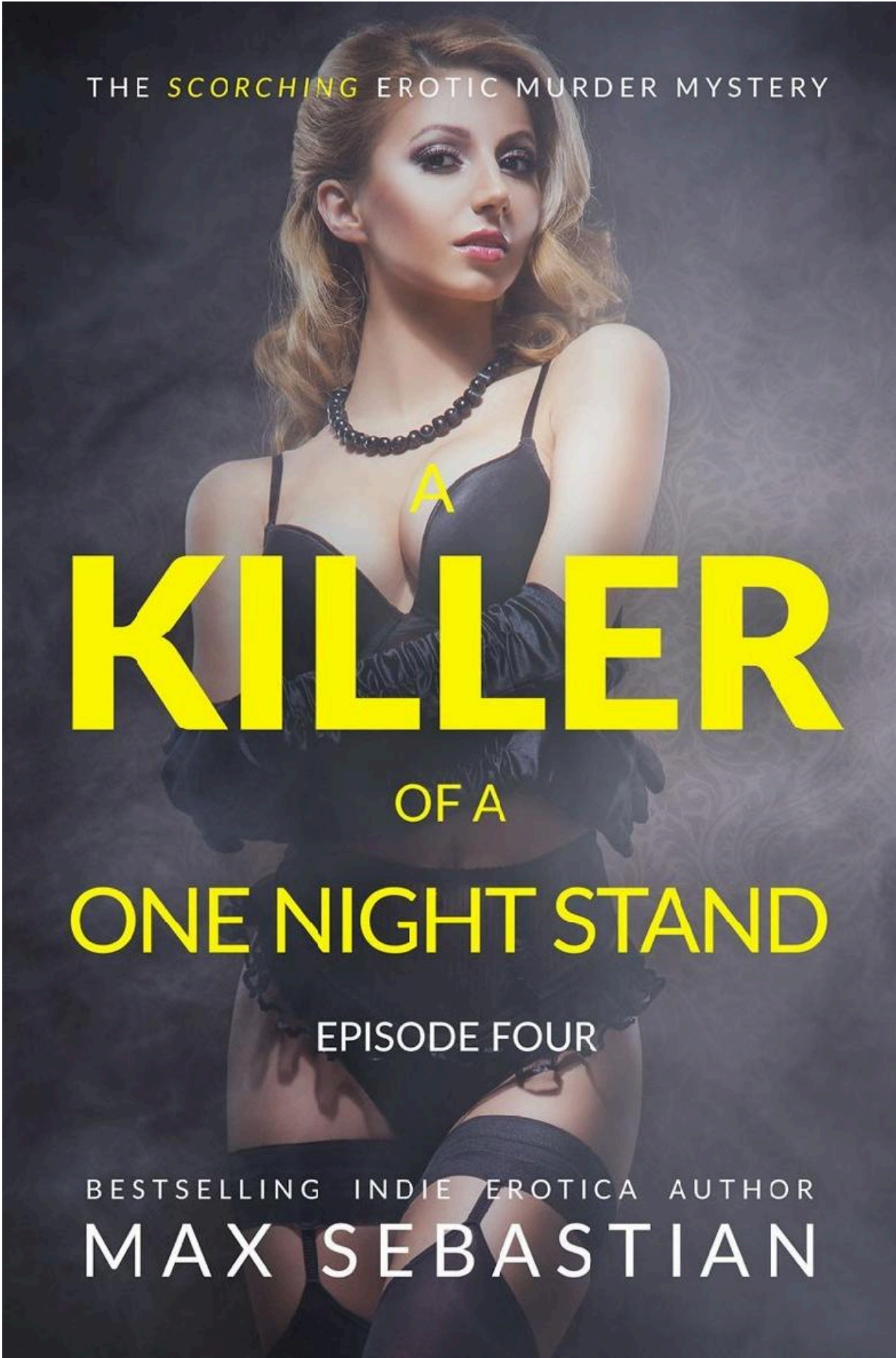
A woman with blonde hair, wearing a black corset, black gloves, and a black beaded necklace, is the central figure. She is looking slightly to the right with a subtle smile. The background is dark and textured.

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About the Author

Max Sebastian has written more than 20 novels, and regularly tops the bestseller lists for steamy erotic fiction. He began writing erotica at Literotica.com nearly two decades ago, and broke into the wider world of publishing in 2011.

Since then, Max has become well-known for sensual, steamy adventures in which couples explore thrilling alternatives to monogamous relationships, on their way to a very raunchy happy ever after—including menage stories, wife-sharing, hotwives, cuckolding and partner-swapping in various forms.

Max lives in London, England, and loves to hear from readers. Visit his website at www.maxsebastian.net.

Some of Max's Other Books

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A Killer of a One Night Stand

Episode Four

Max Sebastian

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Prologue

“M ulray. Adams wants that file.”

“Adams? What—”

“Now.”

She looked up from her desk and the cogs were whirring, but she had no clue what Ferguson was talking about. Nobody had asked her to get a file, least of all Detective Superintendent Adams. She never had dealings with him. And who asks a Detective Inspector to fetch a file? She wasn't a secretary. Adams had his own secretary.

But Ferguson shrugged and moved on, he didn't care.

She cautiously rose to her feet, felt her stomach cramp a little. Adams was senior, after all. He was at the captain's table for this investigation. Was she in trouble?

Glancing over to Adams' office, she received a little jolt to see the DS standing behind his desk, looking her way. He gave a very quick flick of the hand to signal to her his wish to see her, but then he appeared to be talking to another man who was seated to the side of the room, and he didn't give her another look.

Mulray felt a sudden chill in the air. He definitely wanted to see her, then.

She knew that for much of his career DS Adams had been part of internal affairs.

He was on the Black Widow investigation now, though, surely? Even so, the silver-haired Adams could send a shiver down the spine of any police officer, probably even the Chief Super.

On her feet, she was trying to look relaxed, casual. It wasn't just that she felt a hint of injustice in the air, but she didn't want her colleagues to know she was in trouble, or that she had failed at something. That she was about to face a roasting.

Whatever file he wanted from her, he certainly hadn't asked for it. There'd been no messages, no email. She could not be held to account for something she had never been asked to do.

Her walk of shame, if that was what it was, seemed long, but she kept her chin up.

"Mulray, thank you." Adams did not show any hint of anger as she quietly opened the door and stepped inside his office.

"Sir. Ferguson said you wanted a file—"

He smiled. "I wanted to see you without causing any kind of a stir in the office.

Take a seat. Mulray, this is Sterling."

Adams indicated the other man, a strange gaunt man with a pale, almost gray face, salt-and-pepper hair and a goatee that made him look like some kind of pirate. The man stepped behind her and closed the door as Mulray took her offered seat in front of the DS's desk.

"This is Sterling. Works for Her Majesty's Government."

"We've been following your reports with interest, Detective Inspector," the man said, his voice smooth and effortlessly upper class. Mulray hardly bothered to hide her surprise that someone had paid any attention to her reports.

Was he Justice Department, or something more... covert? Mulray didn't feel it appropriate to ask as the man retook his seat on the chair almost hidden by a laden coat stand.

"You won't have heard much yet," Adams said, pressing both his hands flat on the empty pine desk in front of him. Mulray thought suddenly: who has an empty desk? Only someone moving in... or out. "There's been another one," he went on. "It's getting out of control."

“Oliver Pearson, sir?” she asked, a little confused as to whether he was referring to victim number five or—

“No. Another one. And that’s three in a month. And this latest one... was particularly unfortunate.”

Another one, another murder. Mulray felt her blood go cold. This really was getting out of control. For a city like London, which was largely unused to serial killings, the sudden rapid pace of developments in this case could cause panic.

“Chief Superintendent Clarke has written a resignation letter, and the minister has accepted it,” Sterling said. He appeared to be lighting up a small cigar, which Mulray was somewhat surprised he could do without incurring the wrath of Adams, or setting off the fire alarm.

“There’s going to be a few changes around here with Eric gone,” Adams said, talking under his breath as though he might be overheard.

Mulray looked again at the empty desk between them, and then up to the Detective Superintendent’s lined face.

“Are you... taking charge, sir?” she said, taking her hunch for a ride.

Adams nodded. Somehow, it shocked Mulray. As someone so new to the job, at least this side of it, she was suddenly in an office talking one-on-one to the man now leading a major murder investigation, and perhaps the biggest in the last two decades.

He sat back in his chair, his hands lacing together over his small but round belly, like one who had come to the end of a long, heavy meal. “I’m not going to piss around, Detective Inspector. I know talent when I see it, and I need talent around me now.”

“Thank you, sir.”

“It’s not strictly by the book, what you’ve been doing. I mean, I’m sure shrinks would say it makes total sense for those affected by the same kind of crimes to talk amongst themselves, but it’s never been done by us.”

“No sir.”

“But it’s thrown up some interesting ideas.”

“Yes sir.”

“This website of yours. Our IT boys have ruled it out of the investigation two,

three times. And still it’s coming up in your reports.”

“There are too many coincidences around it, sir,” she said.

Adams nodded. “Our friends in government have brought to our attention the added coincidence that it appears that Lord Douglas Moss provided a fair portion of the start-up capital for this particular website. Or one of his funds, at least.”

Sterling said: “His investments have been rather well concealed of late, not that they weren’t always fairly well obscured. But when he decided to join the Westminster set... well, he had some good accountants.”

“So another coincidence?” Adams said. “Or perhaps as well as investing in it, Lord Moss was dipping into using it, as well. And thereby he met our killer.”

Mulray said: “Are we talking about Lord Moss, sir? I understood all that was...”

Sterling sniffed, and stroked his beard. “Lord Moss is in play, Detective Inspector. Officially.”

Adams said: “We’ve been handed all the files on the case. There are still some details that are above our security clearance, but particularly after your last report, we’re linking this one into the Black Widow investigation.”

Mulray felt a ripple of self-satisfaction that something she had written up might have influenced an investigation that had attempted to sideline her by making her a mere liaison officer.

“You’ve logged the evidence that Julian Foster interviewed Lord Moss?” he asked her.

“I have.”

“And the next-door neighbor?”

“I talked to her. She confirms that Julian Foster visited the Moss residence on a number of occasions.”

Adams nodded. “You did well keeping in contact with Mr Fielding,” he said solemnly. “He’s been quite ambitious, it would appear.”

“He has.”

“And you’ve already made contact with our friends in the Services,” the senior detective smiled, and Sterling nodded.

“It would appear so,” Mulray said, and then turned to Sterling to say, “You know he thought he was being followed?”

Sterling laughed, “Not us. As you know—we have closer eyes on him than that.

No, we’re not entirely sure who might have been tailing him. They can’t be good if he’s spotted them. It’s something we’re looking into.”

“Can I ask what will happen... under your new leadership, sir?” she asked Adams.

Adams nodded. “I’m going to ask you to maintain your approach, liaising with the next of kin.”

“Yes sir,” Mulray said, her tone betraying a hint of disappointment.

“But,” he added, “I’ll give you more resources and you’ll have free rein to take this where you need to.”

She smiled, “Thank you, sir.”

“I’m impressed, Mulray. I’m not going to hide that. I’m not a fan of affirmative action if it means diluting the abilities we have available, but we need to recognize talent when we see it.”

“Yes, sir.”

“You’ll be taking a big step up with this.”

“Yes sir, thank you, sir.”

Sterling stood up, folding his arms. “We’ll be in touch, of course,” he said. “But be careful. I guess you’ll want to get in contact with Lady Moss.”

“I would think so, sir.”

He nodded. “Just take care. They’re... well connected. Things could get very

grubby very quickly if the two of them are linked publicly with a website of that nature.”

“Of course.”

“I mean, an investment is one thing, and this one can be covered up and denied until Kingdom come. But it’s well documented in our files that Lord Moss couldn’t have used a website like that himself...”

“Not himself, no,” Mulray nodded. “Perhaps for someone else.”

Taking a step toward the door, Sterling paused. “Someone else?”

Mulray felt comfortable in her connecting of the dots. She said: “Perhaps he was using it... for his wife’s benefit, if you get my meaning.”

The two men looked at her, and for perhaps the first time in the entire meeting, it seemed they were getting new information.

She said: “From what we’ve seen, a certain proportion of the men using that website are not seeking women in order to have affairs. They’re looking for other men to have sex with their wives.”

There was a pause as the information sank in.

Adams said: “And you’ve seen evidence of this happening?”

Mulray nodded. “I wasn’t entirely sure it was relevant, so I may only have glossed over it in my reports... but it’s a theory that Julian was

writing a book about this... wife-sharing... and perhaps that was why he wanted to interview Lord Moss beyond simply an obituary.”

“Extraordinary,” Sterling said.

“Why would men want others to fool around with their wives?” Adams asked.

Sterling put his hand on the door handle. “Oh, it’s commonplace, George. Lady Moss, eh? Well. Plenty worse happens among the corridors of power. Mulray, be bloody careful, whatever you do. And for God’s sake don’t start accusing her outright of cheating on her husband—even if he was there in the room cheering

her on.”

“No sir.”

One

He could understand what people said when they suggested their lives flashed before their eyes in the moments before death claimed them.

As he felt that cold steel at his throat, the cruel point running across his flesh, his panicking brain seemed to choose a series of memories at random to focus on, instead of the shocking fact at hand, that Jonah Fielding was just about to cease to exist.

The image of his first schoolteacher popped into his head, Miss Lemon. He probably hadn’t thought of her since he was knee-high to a grasshopper.

His parents dishing out a grand barbecue for him and Nate and all their friends during a summer when they’d been what, 10, 11 years old?

His first real girlfriend, a brunette by the name of Penny who had been a classmate of his in his last year of school.

It was probably his brain telling him he’d been loved, he’d affected the lives of others, his existence had not been pointless. It was part of the process of shock, the emergency systems within his brain designed to give him the best chance of remaining sane, so that if there was any

glimmer of a chance of him fighting off this life-threatening event, he would still be mentally capable.

It came with a rush of heat and adrenaline that suddenly seemed to dissipate the intense fear that he felt. Death, when it came, would be painless. He would simply cease to be. Like going into a deep sleep from which he just wouldn't wake up.

“Okay, that’s probably a bit too much.”

“I told you the knife would be going too far.”

“I know, I know.”

He felt confused, completely bewildered as that awful sharp point withdrew from his throat. And there was no pain, no breathtaking agony of cut flesh.

Just the lingering memory of the point being carefully dragged across the skin of his neck.

He felt equally confused at the presence of a new voice, someone who was not Kaia. And the familiarity of that voice...

“Hey Jonah, sweetie, you’re okay. You’re okay, right?”

Jesus. What was going on?

He flinched from the brightness as the blindfold was removed, and from the chill on his face that it left behind. Took him a few moments before he could open his eyes and look into the pretty face of a blonde girl named—

“Emma!”

“I’m sorry,” she smiled somewhat sheepishly.

He sucked in great relieved breaths of air, laced with her wonderfully sweet signature coconut scent.

“What’s going on?” he asked, his brain struggling with the concept of his pretty personal assistant being there in the room with him, saving him from this awful death. Had she followed them? Had she somehow known

that Kaia was the killer? Had she broken in to save him at the fateful time?

He just couldn't get his head round the obvious answer...

"Kaia's my roommate," she said, leaning over him to remove his shackles.

And what was Emma doing in here wearing nothing but her panties? And the Asian girl was sitting there on the end of the bed, pensive, but certainly not overpowered and ready to be carted off to a police station.

He looked up at her apologetic face, her piteous, regretful face, and suddenly felt the strange sense that she'd been in on this all the time.

She had set up the date. She had told him where to go, she had told him who he was dating.

"Your roommate?"

"I know, I know, it seems a bit stupid now," she said. "But I really wanted you to know the kind of danger you're putting yourself in."

"Danger..." He didn't know what to say. He felt a little light-headed.

"Are you upset with me?"

With the shackles off, she kissed him, and things just seemed to slow down in that kiss. God, she was a good kisser. His hands found their way to her soft, spectacular curves, and his thawing brain took in the facts that his favorite blonde had apparently set up a little show-and-tell for him, so that he might see for himself just what a risk he was taking.

"I'm not upset," he said, breathless. "At least... I don't think so..."

He did feel a bit of an idiot, now. She had proven that when push came to shove, if he dated a dominatrix who tied him up, there was no possible way he might avoid his own murder. He would do little better than Nate did.

"I was talking to Detective Mulray, and she was so nice, and I just let go, you know? Told her how afraid I was of—"

“Murray put you up to this?”

That actually made him laugh. It seemed plain ridiculous. The beautiful Detective was not only subtly helping his private investigation, but she was trying to help him prepare in the event that he did come across the killer.

“You have to admit, if you got into a situation like this, there’d be no way you could escape.”

He nodded. Pulled her to him for another kiss. “I suppose you’re right.”

Emma smiled, and said: “Kaia’s not really married, by the way. It was all part of the act.”

He glanced down, and his evening’s date offered him a vaguely apologetic smile.

“Sorry,” she said.

“And you’ve been here all along?” Jonah asked Emma.

She shrugged. “Kaia didn’t mind me watching. I wanted to see you for once, you know, with someone else.”

“And that’s why you’re not wearing anything?”

She giggled. “Kaia didn’t mind,” she said again.

God, it would be a searingly hot thing to be in a bedroom with two such stunning-looking women. But Jonah felt as though he’d just been pulled through a laundry wringer. He also felt a little self-conscious now, having been somewhat shown up by this pair. It meant everything between his legs was decidedly soft.

“I need to use the bathroom,” he said, though it wasn’t true in a biological sense.

He just needed a moment to himself, to make sense of things.

Emma moved aside to let him get up, and glanced at Kaia to indicate something Jonah didn’t quite follow. His muscles ached from his

restricted movement, but he forced himself up off the bed, onto his feet.

“It’s down the hallway, second door on the right,” Kaia said, and as he passed her, he caught Kaia giving some kind of glance back to Emma, perhaps silently asking her if she thought he was really okay.

“I think I nearly peed myself,” he said, trying to keep things light.

“I would have,” Emma smiled warmly, looking as though she was hoping he was in the process of forgiving her.



So this was where Emma lived? It was small, but he guessed it might have been suitable for a couple of students. It wasn’t like the digs up in Oxford, that was for sure. But what could London students do for accommodation in a city of insane property prices?

He did manage to use the facilities in the bathroom, relieving himself of some of the drink consumed back at the Light Bar. Had the whole evening been wasted?

God, all that effort to keep Kaia onside. And she had been acting with him.

What was his definition of an evening that wouldn’t have been a waste? Sleeping with Kaia and then finding out she wasn’t the killer? Well, he’d done that, hadn’t he? He hadn’t exactly gone all the way with her, but it had been fun before she’d pulled that knife on him.

Flushing the toilet, he took a deep breath and looked in the mirror. Well, at the end of the day, he was alive. Perhaps this was the wake-up call he had needed—

perhaps it was an intervention that might even save his life. Because Emma was right. It was stupid of him to allow any date to tie him up, or handcuff him or anything like that.

Maybe they’d have to rethink the whole strategy of dating women hoping one would turn out to be the killer.

After washing and drying his hands, he actually felt better. It seemed to him that Emma was proving herself more interesting with every day—and demonstrating that she probably did feel more for him than just the fact they were good together in bed.

Of course he'd forgive her for this.

He even managed a smile as he left the bathroom, thinking that the fact she'd finally shown him the place where she lived, and introduced him to her roommate, was some kind of step forward in their relationship.

When he returned to the bedroom, pausing in the doorway to announce to all those present that he was in a forgiving mood, and wasn't about to be angry at them for pulling the wool over his eyes after all, what he saw made him freeze in his tracks, floored.

They were lying on the bed together, kissing.



Jonah felt the breath knocked out of his body.

Kaia lay on her back, her black hair flowing over the pillows, her hands reaching up to hold the back of Emma's head as the blonde sucked on her top lip. Emma's hand was lodged between her roommate's thighs, and as they kissed, he saw it moving, caressing her.

God—they were lovers?

He felt the ground unstable underneath his feet.

They were so beautiful together. No wonder so many straight men were obsessed with lesbian porn. Jonah couldn't deny a certain hot tingling returned to his loins.

But this totally transformed what he knew about Emma.

Standing there in the doorway, he kept completely silent, watching them. Emma rose, and planted kisses down the slope of Kaia's chest, her skin pale compared to her roommate's golden color.

Did these two have a longstanding relationship? They looked... familiar together. This certainly wasn't a first time. And Emma had been comfortable enough with Kaia to use her to expose one of the weaknesses of his whole investigation. And comfortable enough to watch Kaia with him, strip off and enjoy the show.

Watching them, Emma moving down to kiss her way up Kaia's shapely legs, Jonah didn't feel the same kind of jealousy he did on seeing Lily with another guy, or on believing Emma had slept with Martin Sallow's friend Clement. There wasn't that same burn, there wasn't the same deep biological impulse triggered inside him to fight for her, to reclaim her.

But he did feel suddenly diminished, somehow, in importance.

And he did feel the cold claws of fear circling his heart. It wasn't jealousy, and yet he was afraid of losing Emma. Or perhaps even that he'd never had her to begin with.

Was Kaia a bit of fun on the side for Emma, another little youthful dalliance while she slowly explored her feelings for Jonah? Or was Jonah a bit of fun on the side for a young woman already in a committed long-term relationship with her 'roommate'?

He had wrongly interpreted her commitment to him—had to have, if she hadn't even told him about her bisexual side yet. Surely? He would get hurt if he went on believing they were a couple, that they were anything more than just friends with benefits.

But though it torpedoed any confidence he had in his relationship with Emma, this was all so incredible to watch. He found himself hoping that they didn't spot him lurking in the doorway: he wanted to see them.

The pretty blonde did not disappoint, kissing her way slowly along Kaia's inner thigh, and then along the join between her thigh and her torso. And there, she touched her lips down against Kaia's pussy, her nose pressing into her tuft of jet-black pubic hair.

Both women moaned as Emma began to suck on Kaia's pussy lips.

Emma wasn't just fooling around, her moans suggested she was really into it, and to witness that made the hairs rise on the back of Jonah's neck. He could still taste Kaia's flavor on his own lips, smell her on him.

As she licked Kaia, the blonde's hips gently squeezed, as though she was humping the bedsheets, her body craving more attention while she was occupied by the arousing experience of going down on the beautiful Asian woman.

The two women held hands as Emma pushed her face up against Kaia's wet pussy, and it seemed more affectionate than it might be for a simple drunken encounter between two broad-minded young women.

No wonder Emma had had no distaste for Jonah when he'd returned to her after being with another woman. Did she dream of being with those women?

Kaia's moaning turned up a notch, and she raised her knees, her body beginning to undulate as her breathing deepened considerably. Even as she continued to lap at her friend, and Kaia began to press her head more firmly against her, Jonah could see the blonde beaming at how she was affecting Kaia.

So exquisite, the flowing grace of the combined forms of the women sublime—

all those curves, all that smooth skin, silky hair.

Kaia shivered as her climax danced through her frame, and the way she yelled out, Jonah realized that even if he'd been still hiding out in the bathroom, he would have heard—and these women would know he now knew about all this.

But he'd been away from them too long. Even if he had huge things to think about, to deal with, following his simulated murder scene, they had to think he'd be done in the bathroom by now.

"How long you going to stand there watching?" he heard Kaia saying.

Emma looked up from between her friend's thighs, and she was grinning, apparently pleased that he'd been watching them, that he now knew how wicked she really was.

He moved slowly to the bed, trying not to seem like some kind of drooling idiot about all this. Trying to seem, perhaps, as he'd always suspected this about Emma, and it wasn't a big deal to him.

He knelt at the bedside, and almost as though teaching his personal assistant a lesson, moved to kiss her friend on the lips.

Kaia leaned into his kiss, though she could have pulled away. She could have shunned him: she was Emma's lover, not his. She could have mocked him for thinking he meant something to the blonde. But it wasn't like that.

As before, her prickly attitude seemed to melt away as he actually kissed her.

Her lips, her mouth tasted differently than before. Laced with something else: Emma. She must have gone down on her while he'd been in the bathroom.

He felt Emma move up beside him, and felt any angst toward her simply dissolve in the face of the desire he felt for her. If this was how she was, who was he to object? It had been Jonah who had wrongly interpreted their relationship as anything other than just a few fun encounters, that Emma might have feelings for him. Not Emma's fault.

And as for her secret... well, she'd told him now.

He turned and kissed her, and she was grinning ear-to-ear at his knowledge of her, it seemed, at the fact that he seemed to be enjoying the fact that she had this with Kaia. Her expression seemed to make light of all this—and somehow, made Jonah relax and see it just as fun, with no deeper significance.

He kissed Emma, reveling in the fact that he could taste another woman on her lips, and silently, he decided to just go with the flow.

Emma didn't know he'd made the wrong assumption that they were more than just friends with benefits. He could simply back-track to the previously agreed position, no harm done.

Breathless, still trying to keep calm about all this, he said to her: "You never told me you were—"

"Bisexual?" she shrugged. "I don't tell guys on the whole—they'd tend to either get over-excited about it, or get surprisingly judgey about it."

“Are you over-excited?” Kaia asked him, her hand closing around his hard cock.

He turned to kiss her, trying to maintain a zen-like serenity, purely for pride reasons. “I’m definitely excited,” he said quietly. “Excited to be alive, for one.”

Kaia laughed at that. “We were cruel, huh?”

“A little.”

Emma moved down to his legs, where she could kiss around—and then on—his thick shaft, taking over from Kaia’s hands.

He groaned as he felt his sensitive manhood enveloped by the heat of Emma’s mouth, but as Kaia shifted up, putting her arm around his head as she began to suck on his lips, he found his focus drifting to her, his hand slipping between her smooth thighs, fingers dipping into her warm, tight wetness.

He never thought he’d ever be involved in a threesome. Now it was happening, it was all a little too much at once. His senses were swamped by exquisite femininity, his body rippling with pleasure.

Somehow, there was a lot to think about, while at the same time he had to play

down his own arousal in order to maintain control, and not come to his own conclusion too soon.

He didn’t want to miss any of it.

As he kissed Kaia, her hands cradling his head, he saw something different in her. Gazing into his, she was clearly enjoying his touch, his kiss, but there was something else in those dark eyes of hers, too. It seemed to him almost that she was impressed at him, either because he had come through his cruel test unscathed, or perhaps because he wasn’t freaking out after finding out about Emma’s hidden side.

He said: “So before... you tried to kill me... was that all made-up? I mean clearly about your husband...”

“I am a teacher,” she said. “I don’t like sports. I didn’t lie about everything.”

“And the whole... dominant thing...”

Kaia smiled down at Emma, who shared her amusement. “You do like all that, don’t you?”

“You were good at it,” he said, feeling a little sheepish.

She pulled his head back from watching Emma, forcibly. Kissing him, taking what she wanted.

Emma giggled, “He does like that. I felt him jumping in my hands!”

Kaia smiled, said: “Okay, I think it’s high time I had more than just your fingers.

Lie back.”

He did as he was told—but then, so did Emma. The blonde rose from his loins at one little gesture from her roommate, to make way for her. She pulled herself up to kiss his mouth as the beautiful Asian girl briefly put the end of his cock in her hot mouth, then climbed onto him, guiding his almost painfully erect cock to her slippery groove.

Jonah groaned long and low as she sank down on him, taking him inside her incredible tight heat.

“You like how she’s fucking you?” Emma whispered to him.

“Feels good.”

“She’s just using you.”

“Absolutely.”

“I want to use you as well.”

He noticed how hard Emma’s nipples were, and it made him crave them in his mouth. But she had a resolute expression on her face, and as she

lifted a knee over him and climbed over his head, he saw a greater prize swing into view.

Emma supported herself on the headboard as she eased herself gently into place over his face, but as his lips came into contact with her wonderful searing heat, and his tongue familiarized itself with her succulent flavor again, he found that she was pressing herself down on him with a little more force than usual.

Moaning, sighing, gasping as he ate her with enthusiasm, Emma gripped his arm tightly as he himself gripped her thighs, and began to rock back and forth on his face, harder than she had ever done before.

Using him.

He loved it, though it was challenging to keep up with her, to keep his own rhythmic lapping going, to keep his tongue sliding inside her—and also draw breath so that he didn't pass out.

It even took some of his attention away from the glorious experience of Kaia bouncing on his pole, so that he didn't prematurely end it.

Emma used him until he was red in the face, her juices dripping down his chin.

She used him until Kaia came powerfully on his cock, and then made way for the blonde to receive his full penetration.

They switched, so that he was able to enjoy Kaia's efforts to impose her will on his face, and indulge in her own particular flavor, as Emma rode him ecstatically, and the two women kissed each other above him.

She made him come, hard. They both did, that night. It was a long one, with little sleep all around.

He needed his breaks, of course, which were suitably taken with a glass of wine in his hand as he watched Emma and Kaia having fun without him. But he came back again and again, thickening up, re-entering the fray, sustaining himself a remarkable period.

The sheer relief of being alive gave him an incredible amount of energy.

Throughout the amazing night, the thought lingered at the back of his mind—he knew after his eye-opening experience, they were going to have to come up with a different strategy to catch this killer.

Two

Despite his long, demanding night, Jonah awoke after only a few hours' sleep as the sun came up in the early morning.

His brain was spinning too much for him to drift back to sleep.

He left Emma curled up in bed with her friend, grabbed his clothes and stepped out of the bedroom. In the small kitchen off the central hallway, he found some coffee and a loaf of bread to make toast.

Emma's laptop was sitting on the counter, and as he waited for the toaster to pop, he opened it. The screen lit up to offer him access without requiring a password.

She had been working on Julian's account, and Jonah felt grateful to her as he laid eyes on her notes within a Word document open just above an Internet browser that still displayed the No Strings website.

She had taken down a list of the usernames of the men and women Julian had been in contact with in the year or so that his account had been active. Against a few of the male usernames, she had put the names of the Black Widow's victims

—including Nate.

Jonah drew up the browser window and typed the username Emma had put Nate's name against into the search box—"adrian3019".

He felt a sudden jolt as the search result came up with a profile on which the avatar picture was unmistakably showing the face of his brother. God. It really was him. Jonah went to Julian's messages, and now scrolled through until he found correspondence between the journalist and Nate.

It wasn't much, but Julian had politely stated that he was writing a book on the concept of sharing wives in contemporary society, and that he was approaching people whose profiles suggested they were involved in this kind of activity in order to find out more about their experiences.

Nate had been receptive to the idea of sharing his experiences with Julian Foster under the condition that his name or any identifying details would be kept firmly away from the published book. Julian, of course, had assured him they would be.

The two of them had arranged to meet for lunch at the Jamie Oliver Italian restaurant around the corner from Nate's office at Churchill Place.

That was about as far as their correspondence on the No Strings messaging system went—but it was enough to set Jonah's pulse racing again. Real confirmation that his brother had met Julian Foster.

Emma's list contained question marks next to her suggested names, suggesting she couldn't be completely sure that the profiles of the men in question were those of other Black Widow victims—Martin Sallow, Oliver Pearson, and of course Lord Moss himself. The profile pictures were just too unclear to be 100%

certain. But her guesses looked reasonable enough to offer the impression that these guys really were connected by whatever project Julian Foster had been working on.

A connection like this suggested some kind of motive: they had been killed for a reason. Was it because they'd talked to Julian Foster for his book?

Wife-sharing might be taboo in society, but it was hardly illegal. Could a book detailing the experiences of participants really be dangerous enough to provoke multiple murders?

Jonah was gazing off into the middle distance, not really focusing on anything, when he suddenly realized the other significance of knowing his brother's username. He might find his way into Nate's own account on No Strings.

It came down to the "forgot password" feature.

On Emma's laptop, Jonah logged out of Julian Foster's account, and now on the log-in page clicked on the "forgot password" link. The website asked him for his username, and then drew up a series of personal, identifying questions.

Jonah nearly laughed out loud as he responded to questions including who had been Nate's favorite school teacher, what was the first name of the person he'd first kissed, and what city or town was it that his nearest sibling lived?

With that, he was offered a screen on which to change his password to something more memorable, and then he was into Nate's account.

Jonah's heart was pounding. Was the name of his brother's killer—or at least her picture, her website profile—stored within this account?

He clicked on Nate's messaging system hoping to find out the last person he'd dated. But there was nothing in Nate's message box. Jonah felt a little crushed.

His brother had deleted all his messages. Why would he do something like that?

Even the correspondence with Julian Foster, which he knew existed, was gone.

Nate's diary on the system, which might have charted his dates, was similarly blank.

He felt empty, hollow. Well, he'd obviously been expecting too much from this.

Nate would hardly have written up a big detailed account of who his killer had been.

Jonah clicked through to the stats page for his brother's account. Nate was a four-star guy, it seemed. He'd had his account for four years, and he'd had 223

dates during that time, it seemed.

Toward the bottom of the stats page, there was a link to "favorites". Jonah clicked on it, and it drew up a list of female profiles, all of which, it appeared, Nate had selected as favorites. Were these favorites he'd already dated? On the profiles were their star ratings, and as Jonah

hovered the mouse pointer over them, the white star turned yellow, and a pop-up box invited him to give them his own rating if he'd dated them.

It suggested that he hadn't dated these women, that they were profiles he'd highlighted for future dates. Was one of these women the one he had dated on his last night?

Jonah felt a sudden rekindling of hope inside his chest.

How could he make use of this information? Tip off the police? But he could hardly be sure that this list of women included the murderer.

What he could do, he decided, was note down the usernames of these women, and then try to date some of them, either because the murderer was among them, or because it might give him a feel for what type of woman Nate went for—and

therefore what type of woman his killer was likely to be.

It was a fairly laborious process, but he went to sit on one of the couches in the small living room to get it done. After noting down the usernames, he logged out of Nate's account before logging into his own account. Then, he searched and found the women from Nate's favorites list, and made them favorites for his own account.

Emma could work on tempting some of them into dating him. It had to be the right thing to do.

"She let you use her computer?"

Jonah looked up to see Kaia walking in, wearing only a set of black bra and panties. Well, she hardly had to hide her modesty from him any more.

"Of course," he said. "Why wouldn't she?"

"You know you're the first boyfriend she's ever brought home?" She stood in front of him now, flaunting herself, running her hands down her body. "You must be special."

"I thought you brought me home."

A little grin at that. "She sent me out to get you, didn't she?"

He said: “So that was the first time you two...”

She shook her head, “Oh we share guys all the time—but usually, I bring them home.”

Standing there right in front of him, she had her thumbs hooked in the waistband of her panties, and now toyed with her underwear as though about to pull them down.

“You’re up early,” he said.

“Touché,” she said. “You think I can just stay in bed all day?”

“So are you really a teacher? Or was that part of the lie?”

“I teach. I lecture. I supervise.”

“Kindergarten? Primary school? Somehow I don’t see you associating with young kids.”

She smiled. “Students, actually. University.”

Jonah raised his eyebrows. “Emma’s university?”

“Now that would be a scandal,” she said. “So we’re just roommates, officially.”

Jonah nodded. Kaia did seem slightly older than Emma, but it was very hard to tell. Perhaps he only thought that now because she’d told him she was a lecturer, not an undergraduate.

“How long have you two been... seeing each other?” he asked her. Interested, but feeling that it had a bearing on his relationship with the blonde.

Kaia shrugged, “Couple years. It’s nice. We get to share.”

She climbed onto his lap, light, flexible almost like some kind of gymnast, threw an arm around his shoulders and kissed him. He was surrounded by her familiar subtle, clean scent. Something he’d been so saturated by during the night.

He brushed his hand over her cheek, but then she grabbed it, pulled it down between her legs. Firmly telling him what she wanted.

He slipped his fingers between her thighs, feeling her heat through the thin black cotton of her panties. She moaned as he pressed down on her pussy, her clit, and sucked on his mouth as his fingers massaged her there in little circles.

“Don’t you have to get to work?” he asked, breathless, as she came up for air.

Her panties were soon saturated with her wetness. He pulled them aside to slide one finger inside her, and continue stirring up against her sensitive clit in the way that seemed to drive her sighs and moans.

“Oh, there’s time enough for a last taste of you,” she said, closing her eyes and straining as his movement accelerated around her clit.

“A last taste?”

Kaia opened her eyes, and looked into Jonah’s with what seemed almost like pity. “You really like her, don’t you?”

“Of course.”

“No, but really,” she said. “I saw it all the time last night while you were with her.”

Jonah shrugged. “I like her. Is there a problem with that?”

She pressed her hand down over his as he continued to massage around her clit through her wet panties. “God, men aren’t supposed to know how to do that...”

she sighed. Then she looked at him again. “Emma’s like me,” she said. “We get... distracted by all the beautiful men out there.”

“And why is that a problem?” Jonah asked, but couldn’t help but feel a hollow She said, “Don’t get hung up on her, Jonah. She’ll hurt you if you do.”

“I won’t,” he said, kissing her, then laying her down on the couch to seek out another taste of her sweet pussy. As he lost himself in the beautiful Asian, he only wished he believed it himself.

Three

It was beginning to rain as Jonah stepped out onto the street, the overcast sky keeping it vaguely dark even with the dawn done and gone. There was a chill breeze, too, which made him turn up the collar on his jacket. Where had the warm summer gone?

Hunching his shoulders and ducking his head to keep the rain from venturing down his neck, his focus on keeping out of the puddles forming on the cracked paving slabs underneath his feet, he almost missed the young woman standing there in the street, leaning up against a car.

He caught a glimpse of her serious shoes and knew instantly who it was—not that many women were in the habit of waiting for him on the street.

“Detective,” he said, raising his voice to avoid losing it in the weather. “Fancy seeing you here.”

“You want a lift?”

“Of course. What would I do without Her Majesty’s Metropolitan Police Taxi Service?”

She gave a small nod, but it was just too miserable out there to dwell long enough for any smart retorts. Without another word, she rounded to the other side of the vehicle and the driver’s door.

Jonah was more than a little relieved to get out of the rain. His relief was only momentary.

“There’s been another one,” she said, pulling off her rain jacket and dumping it fairly unceremoniously in the back seat.

“Another one?”

“I’m guessing you haven’t seen the news yet.” She pulled away, and Jonah

wondered if she was simply taking him home, or whether she was taking him somewhere en route that might be helpful to the investigation.

“Kelvin Selmer.

Another City trader. A little more senior than the last few victims.”

“Selmer?” The name rung a bell.

“Worked in your brother’s firm, actually.”

The recognition clicked in his head. Selmer. Nate’s boss, or the guy above Nate’s boss. VP of Europe or something like that—Graham had mentioned him.

“I’ve heard of him,” he said. “I think he was a couple of rungs up the ladder from Nate.”

“Nate spoke of him to you?”

Jonah felt something of a weight on his shoulders. He let out a deep breath.

What was Nate’s professional reputation worth now, anyway, compared to the need for justice? Even if he had gotten involved in some kind of insider trading scam, that did not justify his murder.

But Graham had told him about Selmer and the questionable trades Nate had apparently made before his death. Graham was very much alive, and if he was caught feeding information to the police about trading within the company, without the approval of his superiors, his job might be on the line.

Jonah would have to persuade Graham to go to the police with that particular information.

“I think he may have mentioned him,” he said, telling himself it was only a white lie, that if he couldn’t persuade Graham to go to the authorities about what he’d discovered, he would probably have to tell Mulray himself anyway. So he was only delaying the information.

“I think there’s going to be a few City traders out there who decide to curb their dating activity in the next few weeks and months,” Mulray said

as they pulled out onto a main road, headed south. “The Black Widow is certainly proving she has a taste for them.”

Jonah said, “I found Nate’s account on that website. He’d been swapping messages with Julian Foster, promising to meet with him to help him with his book.”

Mulray said: “You hacked into his account?”

“Once I found the username from Julian’s messages, I just told the website I’d forgotten my password for Nate’s account. I guess my brother didn’t choose particularly challenging security questions.”

The Detective nodded, “And I don’t need to warn you not to mess with any potential evidence...”

“I didn’t touch it—but there wasn’t a lot in there. Looks like he deleted his own messages, and a lot of details about who he’d been dating.”

“He deleted it? Why would he do that? He didn’t have a divorce lawyer on the case...”

“Not unless he got married and didn’t tell anyone,” Jonah said.

“So you didn’t find anything?”

“There was a list of women Nate favorited.”

“Favorited. What does that mean—they were his favorite dates?”

“Favorite profiles. Women whose profiles were interesting enough for him to set aside for, potentially, a future date.”

Mulray said: “You think he might have favorited the killer’s profile? If she was the last person he dated through that website, she might still be among those favorites?”

“It’s possible,” he said. “Whether you can track down any of those women from their profiles is another question entirely.”

“Well, I’ll let the team know.”

“Can I ask where we’re headed?” he asked.

“Chiswick,” she said. “Home of Lord and Lady Moss.”

“Seriously?”

She nodded. “There’s a little more news this morning: Chief Superintendent Clarke has stepped down from the investigation. And there’s something of a change of direction planned by his replacement.”

“Change of direction?”

“Firstly, the Lord Moss case has been declassified—at least enough of it to tie in with our investigation. And secondly, we are officially allowed to meet with Lady Moss to talk to her about her husband.”



Lady Moss lived in an affluent neighborhood in Chiswick, a leafy, cozy part of West London where it seemed just plain wrong for anyone to become the victim of a serial killer.

As they drove past civilized parks and quaint little shops, Mulray was telling Jonah unnecessarily to let her do the talking when they arrived, since she was the one there in official capacity.

“I know, I know, you shouldn’t have brought me,” he said. “But you did bring me, Detective.”

“I did. I guess I must like your company.”

“I’m not sleeping with this one, though,” he said.

Mulray rolled her eyes at him and gave him a melodramatic sigh. “You know I didn’t specifically tell you to sleep with Lily. Just keep her company.”

“Right,” Jonah nodded. “That’s what you were thinking. And you haven’t been suggesting to Emma that it might be a good idea to sleep with Martin Sallow’s best friend?”

She shrugged, “She told me you two were only friends. If you were more than that, I would presume she’d say she couldn’t.”

Jonah felt a little tickle of jealousy, but wasn’t going to rise to it, not in front of Mulray.

“I don’t have a problem with it,” he said, feeling awkward, feeling himself blushing in the Detective’s presence. “We’re just friends.”

“And she’s happy enough with you seeing other women, right?”

Jonah stifled a sigh. He knew Mulray wanted to stir things—to meddle in his relationships as he was meddling in her investigation—but sometimes she got a little too close to the edge. She seemed to know just how to stir to get the butterflies all dancing inside his stomach.

He liked Emma. Perhaps it was more than that. But what did they even have in common? Their relationship was all about the sex. For some reason she liked him because he dated other women and came back to tell her about it. She’d probably lose interest in him if the investigation was over and he went back to his quiet life as an academic. She’d probably lose interest in him if he said he wanted to commit to only seeing her.

At the same time, if he went on seeing other women, how could he not accept it when she saw other men?

He’d just have to get used to it.

And anyway, all that was a distraction for now. He should be thinking about the case, about how all the new facts coming to light might connect together to suggest who had killed Nate.

Jonah needed to change the subject.

“So you think Lady Moss will know anything about her husband’s links with that website?”

“It’s going to be a sensitive subject,” the Detective said. “You know he was unable to... well, let’s just say he wasn’t dating women himself on that website.”

“I know about his impotence.”

Mulray nodded. “So assuming Julian Foster was writing a book about wife-sharing, it’s reasonable to say Lord Moss wasn’t the one sleeping with other men’s wives.”

Jonah said: “But he could have been inviting other men to sleep with his wife.”

Silently, he wondered if Nate had ever dated Lady Moss.

“Well, she’s hardly going to open up about that. But we can see how she reacts to the suggestion.”

They turned down a little street next to a large red-brick church that looked somehow out of place, the architecture faintly Italian, somehow, perhaps from some rustic village in the middle of Tuscany rather than West London. A Roman

Catholic church, according to Mulray.

The street was lined by large trees, and the houses either side were quite large by London standards—it made him think of North Oxford, and the leafy street on which he rented a room.

Mulray pulled into the driveway of a large red-brick detached house that Jonah thought had to be worth at least ten million being located in this part of town.

“So now you’re cleared to look into the website, what are your colleagues doing back at Scotland Yard?” Jonah asked as the DI switched off the engine.

“Once the authorization goes through, we’ll have more of them to investigate this particular lead,” she said. “In the mean time there’s still a lot of other leads and donkey work to get through.”

“Donkey work?”

“House-to-house calls, to see if neighbors of victims saw anyone suspicious calling on them. Tracking down hundreds of hotel guests to see if they remember anything unusual on the nights in question, examination of key pieces of evidence from all the various scenes of crime...”

“And someone has to get the doughnuts,” he said as they climbed out of the car.

“Investigating officers do get hungry,” she said, deadpan.

Set back a little from the road by a small tree and bush-filled front garden and gravel drive, it wasn’t perhaps quite as large a house as you might expect for a billionaire. The location, though, probably added a zero to its price tag.

“Thought they’d live in a palace,” he murmured as they turned into the driveway.

Mulray nodded, “This is one of their five homes in the UK. Their little pied-à-

terre in London.”

“What do you do with five homes?”

The house projected a feeling of immense calm, perhaps helped by the warm red of the brick, the tidy clean white surrounding the windows and the ivy snaking

its way casually up the facade beside the large bay window. Yet there was also an inherent mournful quality to the place, from the gloom of the unlit interior seen through the tall glass panes, though no doubt also from the feelings projected by Jonah himself as its audience—his knowledge that there was an immense sadness contained within these high-priced walls.

As they walked up to the spotless white front door, which had a tiny little portico-style triangle above it, Jonah noticed a forlorn toddler’s pedal car lying outside the front door. As with Julian Foster, Douglas Moss’s murder had left a child or children without a father.

The door was answered by a fairly young dark-haired man—mid-twenties, Jonah would have said—in a smart but understated suit.

“Detective Mulray?”

“Yes. And this is Mr Fielding, who is assisting us with our inquiries.”

The man nodded, and stepped back while holding the door for them. “Do come in. I am Reynolds.”

Jonah tried not to feel odd about someone younger than him working as a butler.

He supposed you had to start somewhere. The man had the right clipped Downton Abbey-esque tones for it.

They walked into a small entrance hall in which a modest staircase descended from an upper landing down to the parquet floor.

The décor was understated, modern, yet everywhere you looked there were touches of elegance and luxury, from the minimalist silver table lamps sitting on a teak sideboard to the small oil portraits hanging on the white walls.

Scandinavia had torn up the English upper class design book.

“I’m afraid Lady Moss doesn’t see too many visitors these days,” said Reynolds as he led them through the small hall into a designer kitchen that felt underused.

“We’ll try not to take up too much of her time,” Mulray said quietly.

Reynolds nodded, and seemed almost to Jonah as though he was quietly granting them his consent to meet with his employer. He showed them through to a bright

conservatory, where various plants seemed to struggle for space against brightly colored children’s toys.

An elegant blonde sat in a large wicker chair flanked by floral cushions. On the slate-tiled floor in front of her, on a Persian rug, a small dark-haired boy was playing with a set of dominoes.

“Lady Moss, may I present Detective Mulray and Mr Fielding.”

Lady Moss was certainly beautiful, her pale blonde hair tied back in a French braid to reveal a long neck and slender shoulders uncovered by her dark blue top. He wouldn’t have said she needed much make-up with

her bone structure, but the total absence of it did lend her a hint of the melancholy. She was also perhaps a little undernourished.

She was too young to be a widow, just like Lily Foster. But she also seemed too young to be a government minister's wife, too young to have a husband in the closing years of his career. And they'd been together five years, too. A trophy wife she might have once been, but the experience, and possibly motherhood as well, had granted her the kind of poise, decorum and maturity that a simple trophy wife could not have.

"Thank you, Reynolds," she said, then looked at each of her visitors. "Well I must say, it's a relief to have a visit from the police for once, rather than those ghastly men from the security services. Do sit."

Her American accent was a surprise, but her years living in London, and among the upper end of the social scale, had given her an unusually formal inflection with more than a splash of English influence.

As they took their own matching, though much smaller wicker chairs, Mulray said, "It's good of you to see us, Lady Moss..."

But the blonde woman cut in: "I've been so sure for so long that Douglas was simply in the wrong place, at the wrong time. And yet the men from the Ministry were always so very sure it was the Russians or the Iranians or Al Qaida. Please tell me you people are more interested in grounded reality than fanciful tales of espionage or geopolitical intrigue?"

Mulray paused, and nodded, glancing at Jonah as though for support.

She said, "Originally, your husband was at a business meeting at the hotel..."

"He liked to stay overnight when he was in town," she said. "He could drink what he liked and then roll upstairs to bed rather than negotiate a trek across London in the small hours."

"And you believe he let the killer into his room..."

"Well he probably thought she was room service come to dole out another bottle of Bell's," she said, her voice oddly flat, impassive.

Mulray said, “We have reason to believe that the other victims may have met the killer through a dating website.”

“A dating website?”

“And the dating website we know at least two of the victims used was owned by a business in which your husband was an early investor.” Jonah looked at Mulray as she threw down the gauntlet for their whole interrogation.

Lady Moss laughed, but without any real amusement. “Ten years ago Douglas was throwing money at anyone in the tech sector if they had half a brain and an idea. He didn’t have a clue about what any of them were doing, but he was certain one of them would be the next big thing.”

“But he never would have looked at a website like that?” Mulray asked, and from her inside jacket pocket, produced a folded piece of paper, which bore a screenshot of the No Strings website.

Mulray was treading carefully, but this was a line of questioning that wasn’t entirely conducive to treading carefully.

“He never cheated on me, Detective, if that’s what you mean. He was an angel.”

An awkward silence settled between them like a bad smell.

Lady Moss sighed. “I thought it was well understood that my husband was simply a case of mistaken identity.”

Trying to soften the mood, Jonah said, “I don’t think anyone thinks your husband was unfaithful. It’s just something that needs to be double-checked and crossed off the list.”

The blonde woman seemed to release a portion of her tension.

Jonah said, “We have to ask whether you might have used a dating website yourself. Or whether your husband might have used it on your behalf.”

“On my behalf?” she said sharply.

He said, “Some of the people using the website in question were in the habit of setting up dates for their spouses.”

“Well it sounds terribly far-fetched to me,” Lady Moss sniffed. “I know some people were trying to suggest my Douglas might have consorted with prostitutes, as though that wasn’t a ridiculous thing to suggest. But to say that—”

“Oh, we’re certain that it was simply mistaken identity,” Mulray said. “You understand that because of your husband’s investment in that particular website, we had to double-check the coincidence.”

Jonah was impressed at Mulray’s professionalism—this was not the easiest conversation to have with someone. Lady Moss seemed tired more than anything, though Jonah thought maybe she just didn’t have the energy to make her anger clearer.

“My colleagues are beginning to believe there could be certain synergies between the victims,” the detective said. “What I mean is—”

“I know what you mean, detective,” Lady Moss said. “My husband was in mergers and acquisitions—I know what synergies are. Good for investors, not so good for the people on the ground.”

Mulray nodded, and paused before speaking. She seemed to be purposefully taking her time, slowing down, presenting a sedate picture of calm as she spoke to the emotionally bleached blonde.

“We’re looking into the possibility that there was a reason why the killer might have targeted certain victims,” she said, “in the hope that we might protect future victims and even identify who the killer is.”

Lady Moss took a deep breath and seemed to be trying to be understanding again.

“Douglas never cheated on me—not once, Detective,” she insisted. Jonah looked into her eyes and believed her. “And don’t think he didn’t have opportunities, either.”

“What do you mean by that?”

“Douglas was an attractive man, Detective Mulray. He was in a high-powered job and then he was a government minister—of course he had opportunities. But he wasn’t interested in any of that.”

Mulray looked at Jonah briefly. He shrugged. He felt a little useless, actually. A third wheel who shouldn’t even have been there.

Almost without thinking, he heard himself asking the tired widow: “Uh... sorry, Lady Moss. Could I possibly... use the facilities.”

His subconscious wanted a break from this pressured meeting.

Lady Moss looked at him for a moment or two, not quite getting what he wanted. Then she seemed to remember he wasn’t police, that he was like her, an unfortunate drawn into this mess by a random killing. “Of course. Go upstairs, if you don’t mind—the downstairs loo is full of Christopher’s things.”

“Thanks,” he said.

“It’s the second on the left. Reynolds will show you.”

The young butler appeared as if by magic, leading him wordless back into the kitchen, through into the entrance hallway and up the stairs.

Upstairs the house continued to resemble the cover of an interior design magazine, though to Jonah its perfection seemed to undermine any sense of happiness in the place. This was a family home that had been ruined by a traumatic and violent murder.

Most of all, it made you feel sorry for the little boy, Christopher.

Reynolds showed him to a small but high-ceilinged bathroom that was as stylishly kitted out as the rest of the house. He thanked the butler, who gave him a polite nod to suggest there was no need to thank him, and then closed the door as the man wondered away.

While using the facilities, Jonah felt the influence of his recent experiences shaping his thinking about this particular household. How long had Reynolds been working here as the butler? Since before Lord Moss had passed away?

There wasn't a shred of evidence, and it was probably just his own filthy mind making things up, but he wondered if Lady Moss hadn't hired a young, virile butler for a reason. Or if Lord Moss had hired him for his wife's benefit.

After using the facilities, Jonah emerged to find there was no sign of Reynolds in the hallway outside.

He paused outside the bathroom door to listen for any hint that the butler was nearby—or that he might be walking back to collect him. Perhaps the man simply assumed Jonah would be able to find the way back on his own.

Silently, he wandered along the hallway, figuring that if Reynolds found him, he'd simply act as though he had been looking for the butler to escort him back downstairs to the conservatory.

The hallway ran along the whole length of the house, with doors shooting off either side, although not on the landing overlooking the floor below.

The silver-framed pictures along the walls were not expensive artwork, as was displayed downstairs, but photographs of various family occasions.

As Jonah peered at them, he saw that many of them appeared to show dinner parties—Lord and Lady Moss playing host to all manner of people. A few faces Jonah even recognized as politicians, musicians, even a well-known actor or two. He spotted the face of an Oxford Don he recognized well enough from his time up in the City of Dreaming Spires.

A few pictures showed Christopher with his parents, while some offered formal glimpses of Lord Moss meeting famous dignitaries in his role as government ministers.

Along the hallway, Jonah ducked his head into one of the rooms—a fairly lavish bedroom complete with four-poster bed, which looked over the wonderful green tones of the garden outside. Through the next doorway along, a beautifully decorated nursery provided a glimpse into Christopher's privileged upbringing complete with its massive cot-bed, elegant rocking horse and so many other toys it looked like a branch of Toys "R" Us.

At the end of the hallway running south from the top of the stairs was the only closed door on the floor, although the heavy handle did move as he squeezed it.

Before opening the door more than a crack, Jonah grabbed a quickly glance this way and that, then listened for any signs that Reynolds might return to find out what was keeping him.

Seemingly safe, he slipped inside the room. Not much excuse if he was discovered in here. Still, the fact it was the only room with a closed door did peak his curiosity.

It was a study, plainly enough, with two of its walls lined with books. With such a high ceiling, you'd need a ladder to get at the uppermost shelves. The room again looked out over the garden behind the house, while the wall opposite carried various old photographs, certificates and mementos.

Jonah saw that once again, a fair few of the photographs showed dinner parties, or Lord and Lady Moss with special guests.

The room smelled of leather and wood polish, which no doubt reflected the nature of its dark furniture, its large desk and desk chair. Jonah got the feeling this had been Lord Moss's study, rather than Lady Moss's, perhaps because the place had been shut off from the hallway.

He sat for a moment in the great dark green leather chair behind the desk.

But what was he even looking for?

Was he really expecting clues to just present themselves? Detectives in television seemed to make all this seem so easy—but really, it was needle in haystack stuff.

The desk had been cleared of any papers, but along with the lamp, elaborate fountain pen set and the Apple desktop computer, there were free-standing

frames displaying family portraits. A beautiful family, the Mosses had been.

Douglas had been almost as fair as his wife—you might have thought they were brother and sister rather than husband and wife. The perfect young family—here was a picture of them with a newborn Christopher, a bouncing blue-eyed babe.

He peered at the bookshelf, which was stuffed full of financial tomes and business memoirs that Jonah assumed had been connected with Lord Moss's business career.

Well, he had to be getting back. Lady Moss and her young companion would be wondering whether he'd fallen into the toilet.

But as he was creeping toward the door, he heard a sound outside in the hallway

—the creak of a floorboard. Jonah froze. He'd left the study door open a crack—

if anyone was out there, they were bound to see it.

He waited for what seemed like an era. If Reynolds had returned to collect him for the return journey downstairs, what would the butler imagine he was doing since he had left the bathroom? No immediate solution came to mind other than acting the fool, insisting he had got lost, despite the fact that the navigation in this house was as simple as could be.

Yet he stood there nailed to the spot, paralyzed. It was long past the point at which someone who was truly lost would have realized it, and retraced their steps back out of the room.

His eyes started running along the bookshelves. Across much of the study, austere leather-bound volumes sat perfectly positioned as objects of beauty, collectively casting a sensible, academic atmosphere through the room. Yet in this corner, a few shelves of paperback books seemed out of place, offering fiction instead of history or business—and not even the classics or literature.

Diana Gabaldon, Nicholas Sparks, Norah Roberts, Kate Mosse. A little enclave of fun within the gloomy world of reality.

And there in amongst the rest, looking fairly innocuous among all the other paperbacks, was none other than “The Watchers” by Alex Higson.

Four

Back downstairs, he returned to the conservatory to find Lady Moss the only one present. A glance out through the French windows revealed that Mulray was standing out in the garden, talking animatedly through her mobile phone.

Lady Moss looked up at him with a completely different expression than that she’d had when he’d left the room.

“Mulray told me who you really are,” she said softly. “I’d thought you were just another bum from the police.”

“Oh, right. I’m sorry we weren’t clear...”

She indicated a silver tray bearing an ornate sterling teapot and blue-and-white china cups.

“It’s nice to meet someone who can appreciate a little more what I’ve been going through,” she said, her tone of voice softer than it had been before his bathroom break, accompanied by an actual smile, though it was laced with empathetic pity.

As he poured himself a cup of tea, Jonah was feeling a little warmer toward her.

“I’m not really part of the official investigation,” he said. “But the Detective has this belief that those of us affected by all this might be able to help each other somehow. You know, by talking about it.”

Lady Moss nodded. “Well, I think it’s very impressive that you’re helping her, even if it’s unofficial. I can just about manage to haul myself out of bed in the morning because Christopher needs me so. Were you and your brother close?”

“Very,” he said, taking a sip of tea and caring little that he’d forgotten to add sugar. He felt a deep sadness suddenly and quite unexpectedly well up from his stomach. You could never be sure when the grief would return, the feelings welling up as though from nowhere.

“So,” she said, and looked behind her toward the garden and the detective, as though checking the coast was clear. “You believe this story about a dating website...”

He said: “My brother told me he was using it a while before he died. And the last time I spoke to him, he was saying he was just about to go out on another date.”

She said, “Well that would seem like an obvious way for him to meet a random serial killer, right?”

He nodded.

She sighed. “It always looks so much simpler on TV, right? The detective just talks to a few people that knew the victim, and then the clues just come along and point out the killer.”

Jonah sipped his tea, beginning to regret its lack of sweetness. “If I was to ask you something... about your husband...” he fumbled, and shot her an earnest expression, laying it out there, hoping their shared grief would protect him from any anger. “You wouldn’t be offended, would you?”

She sighed again. He thought she must have been quite stunning when the ravages of stress and grief were not hounding her. He could fully believe her husband would want to remain faithful to her, even with the temptation that a man of power might have. But that book upstairs suggested he was willing to share her, and that was harder to believe given her beauty.

“Trying to make sense of it all?” she smiled again, warmer than before.

“Something like that. I mean, I don’t need to say anything to them, to the police...”

She nodded. “Shoot.”

“It really could be... quite sensitive.”

“You’re not going to run and sell the story to the Daily Mail, are you?”

“Of course not.”

“So what do you want to know?”

“Did your husband have any... unusual... sexual fantasies?”

She gently shook her head. “I wasn’t kidding before, when I said Doug was an angel. I swear, he wouldn’t even look at another woman.”

Jonah gazed at her clear blue eyes, and she seemed so genuine, he couldn’t see how she could possibly be faking about her husband’s fidelity. But his working theory suggested that Doug was a different part of the wife-sharing equation than Nate. It wasn’t that he had been sleeping with married women with or without their husband’s consent.

Candidly, Lady Moss said, “My husband had certain... issues... that rather affected his performance between the sheets.”

Jonah nodded. “But that didn’t entirely stop his sexual fantasies, did it? He just came at the problem from a different direction.”

“What are you suggesting?”

“The first victim of your husband’s killer visited your husband on a number of occasions,” Jonah said. “A man named Julian Foster.”

Lady Moss said, “That journalist? He was writing Doug’s obituary. Or at least, the first draft of it—obviously we were certain it wouldn’t be used for years, decades. We wouldn’t let any old reporter into our home—”

“But Foster visited your husband more times than he’d need to write an obituary.”

“What are you saying?”

Jonah took a deep breath. “Julian Foster was writing a book about men who allow their wives to sleep with other men. In fact, who enjoy their wives sleeping with other men.”

He saw Lady Moss’s eyes widen with surprise, and perhaps indignation.

“You’re accusing me—”

Jonah shook his hand, trying to dispel the tension, “I’m not saying anything at all

—it’s clear that your husband was simply in the wrong hotel room that night, when the killer took him for someone else...”

“But you want to know if my husband was of the habit of lending me out to his friends?” There was a touch of anger, a touch of betrayal in her eyes.

He sighed, “I just wanted to be sure. Because I think Julian Foster interviewed my brother for his book, and my brother may have been involved in seeing married women with their husbands’ consent.”

She shook her head. “I’m certain that Doug only ever talked to that man about his obituary.”

Jonah nodded, sipping his tea as though to accept that this line of inquiry had been suitably answered.

“I’m sorry,” she said, seeming to relax a little again. “I wish I could make things easy for you—but really, Doug was the most wonderful husband—and father.

There couldn’t have been any reason why he would actively go out to meet another woman at a hotel.”

“Of course,” he said, and now Mulray was returning.

“That was the office,” she said, looking regretful. “I’m afraid we have to be going. Chief Superintendent Clarke has just announced his resignation from the investigation...”

Somewhat surprising them, Lady Moss said, “Eric has stepped down? Well I can’t see that as a step in the right direction, I’m afraid. Who will replace him?”

Establishment circles, how they came together. Of course she knew the Chief Superintendent. She and her husband had probably invited him round for dinner a few times a year.

“Uh... DS Adams. George Adams.”

“Oh, I don’t know him. I’m not sure I like the sound of all this...”

Mulray stiffened, forcing their exit. “Thank you so much for your time, Lady

Moss. I’d like to keep in touch if it’s convenient for you, to keep you updated on any developments in the case.”

“I’d be grateful of it, Detective.”

“And if you ever need someone to talk to—about anything—just give me a call.”

Mulray handed Lady Moss a business card, which she took and held to her chest as though it were a treasured family heirloom. “Thank you,” she said.



“She certainly warmed to you,” Mulray said once they were back on the road, the rain once again making Jonah glad he could benefit from the Metropolitan Police taxi club. “While I was out there in the garden.”

Jonah said, “I think she realized I wasn’t just some faceless police officer, that I felt the same kind of pain she did...”

“Did you ask her about... things?”

“I asked her if her husband might have had a thing about sharing her.”

Mulray smiled, “And how did she take that?”

“She wasn’t so happy about it, but I just said this was a theory based on my brother and Julian Foster, that we all know her husband was just in the wrong place at the wrong time.”

“She’ll hang onto that theory until she’s in the ground herself.”

“I think she might have actually been surprised that I brought up the concept of men sharing their wives,” he said, his brain whirring through

further analysis of their visit to the home of Lord and Lady Moss as he sat there. “I thought at the time she was horrified that I should level such an accusation at her—but perhaps it wasn’t so much horror as fear. Fear of discovery.”

“Interesting.”

“Oh, and upstairs. You’ll never guess what I found in the study.”

Mulray turned to look at him, one eyebrow raised. “You were snooping up there?”

He chuckled, “Don’t tell me you didn’t think of it. Like you thought of stepping out to make a ‘call to the office’ to give me some time with Lady Moss alone, free from police supervision.”

“Okay, what did you find?”

“A copy of Julian Foster’s book. The one about wife-sharing couples.”

Mulray nodded. “Of course, she’d just say he passed it on while he was interviewing Lord Moss for the obituary.”

“It’s just another coincidence, then?”

She shrugged. “So Lord Moss was inviting men over to partake in a little Lady Moss,” she said. “How does that help us? Lord Moss was still in a hotel room with another woman, wasn’t he?”

Jonah said: “Maybe he decided to try the other side of the wife-sharing fence for once.”

“But he was—”

“—Impotent,” Jonah said in unison with her. Then, “Maybe he really was just in the wrong place at the wrong time. But there are too many coincidences stacking up, aren’t there?”

Jonah’s mobile phone buzzed. It made him jump: he wasn’t used to it.

“Jonah, it’s Graham.”

“Graham? Graham.” Mulray looked across at him, one eyebrow raised in curiosity.

“You heard what happened to Selmer?” Graham said.

“Selmer?” It took a moment for his brain to catch up. Selmer was dead.

“You think someone found out about those trading figures I told you about?”

There was a tremor in Graham’s voice. He almost didn’t sound like the man Jonah had occasionally had drinks with since Nate had passed away.

Could the Hotel Killings be related to Nate’s trading anomalies? The link between Nate and Selmer would appear to involve the trading that Selmer had signed off on, rather than Nate’s usual boss. But if the Black Widow had simply been targeting City traders, could Selmer just be some kind of coincidence?

Whatever the answer, it was easy to understand why Graham might be nervous after Selmer’s death.

“I don’t know,” Jonah said. Mulray gave him another look, clearly trying to work out what they were discussing. “Look, we haven’t managed to tie any of the other victims into anything to do with strange trading activities yet.”

The detective mouthed the words “strange activities” as a clear question.

Jonah silently cursed himself for not asking Lady Moss about her husband’s trading activity—he might not have got answers from her, but her reaction to such a question might have offered something. But was she the kind of wife who would have known anything about any of that?

“I just... the thing is...” Graham was struggling to maintain his poise, it seemed.

“Look, they just asked me to take up Nate’s accounts, that’s all,” he said. “I didn’t do anything. I saw a few odd numbers, I asked the guy who’d signed off on them—Selmer.”

“Right.” Jonah tried to think. If he was in Graham’s place, he’d probably be scared of being the Black Widow’s next victim, too. If he wasn’t trying to meet the Black Widow in the hope of taking her down, that was.

“Look Graham, where are you?”

“At home. I don’t think I can stay here. I think I might be in trouble. I think someone followed me last night on the Tube. I’ve got to get out of here.”

“What, leave town?”

Leaving London—would that protect anybody in all this? The Black Widow didn’t have to limit herself to this city, particularly if she had a reason to leave.

Assuming that, what he was beginning to think was true: that the Black Widow had motive in killing the traders she had killed. Was Graham right in thinking the trading anomalies might be the motive, in some way?

“I don’t know. I have vacation time left,” said Graham.

“It’s not going to do any good running away from this,” Jonah said, though he knew his advice was laced with self-interest. If Graham had pertinent

information, he wanted it out there.

Mulray was shaking her head, vigorously. Whispering, “Tell him to go to the police.”

“It’s more than just a trader running wild with a few deals, Jonah,” Graham said.

“There’s something very strange in those numbers. People have been bumped off over less—much less.”

Jonah sighed. He was seriously tired after the night he had. “You should probably talk to the police, Graham. I know it might violate your corporate policy, but this is murder we’re talking about.”

“Not yet. I just need to get my head round this. Got to get away.”

“Come on. Let’s talk. If you give me your address, I could come over. Or later.

Or tomorrow.”

Graham said, “Just give me a few days, Jonah. I just need a break, just need to sort myself out.”

“After the weekend, then,” Jonah was almost pleading.

“I’ll be in touch. Don’t tell anyone about this, Jonah,” Graham said. “Whatever you do.”

Hanging up the phone, he ran head-first into a rather demanding expression from the attractive brunette driving him around town.

Graham didn’t want him talking about this to other people. But Graham was also refusing to talk to the police about this.

Jonah sighed. “Nate may have been involved... in some questionable trading strategies before he died.”

“Questionable trading strategies?” Her tone was sharp. “And you’ve known about this how long?”

He shrugged, “Only a day or two. I tried to get him to talk to you... I don’t know, I figured it was just something that happens, you know? In the City.

Traders do whatever they can to pull out the big numbers.”

“What kind of numbers are we talking about here?”

“I don’t know. Graham said it wasn’t the kind of thing that would bring banks down, but it was... well, enough to raise eyebrows.”

Mulray negotiated the vehicle around a tricky patch of traffic, then said: “How does Selmer fit in?”

“He signed off on Nate’s deals,” Jonah said. “That’s partly why I didn’t think too much of it all. He might not have been quite Nate’s boss, but he was Nate’s boss’s boss.”

“And now he’s dead. Where does he live, this guy Graham. What’s his surname?”

“Fawley. I don’t know where he lives.”

“I’ll have to get in touch with HQ about this—they’ll want him picked up.”

Jonah sighed, “Look, I wasn’t supposed to tell anyone. If you pick him up...

well, he might not open up. He’s fairly sure he’ll lose his job over this.”

“Who cares about his job? If you’re suggesting there’s some kind of motive in all this, related to your brother’s share deals, his life might actually be on the line.”

“Just give me a day or two. I’ll talk to him. Get him to come see you.”

Murray rolled her eyes. “Well for god’s sake don’t let him leave the country. Or London, if you can help it.”

Five

He always did feel disoriented after sleeping for any length of time during the day, but then Jonah had really needed sleep.

After everything that had happened the previous day, with Kaia’s trick, the startling truth about Emma’s sexuality and his own smaller-than-expected place in her affections, and not to mention the visit with Lady Moss and everything concerning Graham’s discoveries, he had collapsed almost as soon as he’d returned to his apartment.

Once again, he didn’t get much packing done. Waking up, there was barely time to get ready for the evening’s planned rendezvous with Bethany.

So he left the apartment without any instructions on how to get to the restaurant.

“You do have a smartphone, don’t you?” Emma said as he called her for assistance. “I mean, I’m talking to you on it right now?”

“Okay, okay, Miss Smartypants.”

“So you know you can just Google it, and—”

“I can’t get it to work. I don’t know, maybe I got the spelling of the restaurant wrong.”

“You got off at Bayswater, right?”

“Yes. I got that far.”

“Okay, so turn left out of the station, walk to the crossroads by the Whiteleys Centre then turn left...”

He was in highly apologetic mood as he arrived late, but on entering the little restaurant on Hereford Road, he was rather surprised to see that Bethany was not sitting at her table all on her own. Not only was her husband sitting there with

her in the red leather seated booths along one wall of the place, but Emma was too.

“Hey, sorry I’m so late,” he said nevertheless as Bethany stood to greet him with a kiss.

“Thought you might have backed out,” Bethany joked with a pretty smile. She was wearing a thin black cardigan over a rather fetching red dress, which reminded Jonah a little of Kaia. Its low cut neckline offered him a tantalizing view of her pale cleavage as she leaned in to kiss his cheeks. Was she still intending to go all the way with him later that evening? That was the point of this dinner, wasn’t it?

“Found it, then?” Emma was in jovial mood, sitting there opposite the couple who were just about to take the final step into wife-sharing territory. She was in a white tank top and jeans—a little more casual than the rest of them, and looking like some kind of production assistant checking on the more glamorous stars of a movie just prior to filming.

“Thanks,” he said, taking his seat next to her. “I presume you’re going to let me know what you’re doing here.”

Oh, he knew she'd be at the restaurant, looking in on Jonah's dinner with Bethany. He even assumed that Richie would be there in the restaurant somewhere, too, watching, agonizing over the idea that his gorgeous wife was having an intimate dinner with another man, a man who was about to commit adultery with her. But what was going on here?

"Richie and Bethany have kindly agreed to help us," she said.

"Help us?" Jonah felt like a bit of an idiot in front of the other couple.

Emma nodded. "So we know that you're not entirely safe whatever you do if you're seeing a woman and she turns out to be the Black Widow..."

As they all watched, the blonde produced a pair of fairly ordinary-looking horn-rimmed glasses, a tiny little black plastic object and an iPad tablet.

"So," she continued, "Bethany has graciously agreed to help us test some new technology that will mean I can see every move you make when you're off

gallivanting with another woman."

Bethany smiled at Jonah, and then nervously at Richie, whereupon she broke out into a very becoming blush. If Emma was going to be testing out this technology and watching Jonah with Bethany, then the look Bethany now gave her husband made Jonah damn sure that Richie was planning on watching, too.

More the merrier, Jonah thought to himself. He'd have to get plenty used to husbands watching if he intended on dating women who were unfaithful by the consent of their beloveds.

"So what's all this, I have to get my eyes tested before we can start doing this?"

he asked her.

Emma held up the glasses for him. "See? They're just clear, no prescription. The lenses are at least curved, so you can't tell they're not doing anything. Oh, the camera's here..."

She pointed to one corner, where a tiny black hole could barely be seen—and if it was, you might imagine it was some kind of imperfection in the frame, or perhaps a tiny screw.

“And this...” she held up the tiny black plastic item “...is your earpiece. So you can hear me—and would you believe it, I can hear you.”

He held it up, and realized it was shaped so he could slip it into his ear.

“Might block out a little of your own sound from one ear, but you’ll soon get used to it, I’m sure.”

He nodded, accepting that this was probably for the best. How would he feel about Emma watching him with another woman? Self conscious?

“Where on Earth did you get all this stuff?” he asked her. “It’s like James Bond stuff.”

“The Internet,” she shrugged. “You can get anything on the Internet these days.

And it all links in wirelessly with my iPad...”

He said, “I need to start calling you ‘Q’, don’t I?”

She laughed, “If that does it for you, sweetie...”

He rolled his eyes, but then turned to the couple seated opposite, saying seriously: “And you’re really okay with all this?”

Richie nodded. He looked thrilled out of his mind, though he was trying to conceal it as best he could. Bethany said: “Emma explained what you guys are doing. We think it’s so important...”

The way she was looking at him made Jonah buzz inside—and started the blood flowing to his nether regions. She wanted him, that much was plain. Now that her husband had unleashed this fantasy, and she had ensured that Richie really did want this, she was eager to go through with it, to take only her second ever man inside her.

“So, we’re going to go set up,” Emma said, forcing Jonah to get up to let her out,

“and you love birds just trot along to your room soon as you’re ready...”

Bethany had to get up too, to let Richie out. Jonah felt his cock thickening between his legs as he watched the young married couple saying goodbye to each other. The trepidation, the nerves, the unabashed excitement in them both.

He actually envied Richie, though he was the one about to seduce the man’s wife.

They kissed, and it was undoubtedly sweet, true love. Would this couple have survived without wading into his fantasy of sharing her? Probably, you had to say. But this way, the fires of lust between them were going to run and run...

“She’s nice, your friend,” said Bethany, sliding back into the booth. “Have you and her ever... you know?”

He couldn’t think what she was talking about. And then he stopped staring at her breasts, and smiled. “Oh, a few times. We’re not really a couple, but...”

“You seem pretty good together.”

Sitting there, Bethany looked mildly terrified, though she was clearly excited, too. He could see her hand shake as she took a sip from the glass of water sitting in front of her.

“So,” he said, “how about a nice bottle of wine?”



As he came out of the bathroom, she was sitting on the couch, and at first he thought she was naked, before she shifted and he saw the white waistband of her panties.

“Wow, you are ready, huh?” he smiled, trying to reassure her.

She was clearly still nervous despite the alcohol cushioning her system, and the fact that it wasn’t their first date and they’d already indulged in

oral sex together, albeit in the darkness of a street corner at night. Her legs were crossed, her arms folded loosely over her lap, her honey-blond hair flowing down one side of her head to hide most of a breast.

“Yeah, I guess so,” she giggled nervously, and gave a shy smile in return.

“Glasses, huh?”

“Uh-huh. Feels a little strange, I’m not really used to them even though they’re not real glasses.”

“You look good in them. Very stylish.”

“Thank you.”

He perched on the couch, a foot or so away from her, running his eyes down her beautiful body. He felt like some kind of cameraman.

“Can you see this?” he murmured. “Can you hear me?”

“Affirmative,” he heard Emma’s soft voice in his right ear. “So you just have to make sure you don’t take off your glasses for sex, right?”

“Right,” he said. “Or if I have to take them off, put them somewhere they can still catch the action.” Bethany looked at him blankly for a moment, since she couldn’t hear the other side of his conversation. “Sorry about this,” he said to her.

“Oh, no, it’s okay. I want to make sure Richie can see this, right?”

Jonah smiled. “Richie can see okay?” he asked the thin air, and panned the tiny

camera in the corner of his glasses over the view of the beautiful young wife waiting for sex.

“Richie can see just fine,” came Emma’s reply. “Nervous, but excited. So, she’s all yours, sweetie.”

He leaned over on the couch, “Your husband can see just fine,” he said, brushing her hair gently back behind her head, revealing the full splendor of her breasts.

“He’s very excited about this.”

“Great,” she giggled again, girlish, slightly awkward.

Jonah asked her, “Can you see anything obvious? I mean, apart from the fact I’m wearing glasses now.”

Bethany looked him in the eyes, and shook her head. “There’s a tiny little hole in the corner of your glasses, but you can’t see it unless you’re really looking.”

Her eyes were flicking between his, and he wondered if she was silently thinking about the fact that her husband was looking out from these glasses as well.

“And the earpiece?” He turned his head to show her his ear.

She shook her head again. “It just looks like a normal ear. I guess if I’m really looking, it’s a little blacker in your earhole...”

He nodded. “Great.” Then he shifted closer to her, his arm moving around her shoulders. “I’m sorry this is a trifle... awkward...”

“Oh, it’s okay,” she said, patting his other hand, then pulling it up to her breast.

Her nipples were already hard, but with the goosebumps over her chest and her upper arms, it could have been from the air conditioning. “I think it being our first time, and with Richie watching...”

He caressed her nipple, and leaned in to touch his forehead to hers, breathing in a chestful of her sweet vanilla perfume.

“So the important thing is,” he said softly, “are you okay with all this?”

She stroked a rogue strand of her hair back behind her ear. “I’m good,” she said,

biting her lip as he brushed his hand over her breasts, from one to the other.

“Tell her she’s beautiful,” came Emma’s voice in Jonah’s ear.

He sighed, hoping he wasn't going to get backseat driving now that his personal assistant had access to his ear all night.

"Your husband's a lucky man," he said, kissing her soft cheek.

"He could have had me all to himself if he wanted."

She seemed to respond to the touching of her breasts, her body moving, her chest rising and falling as her breathing deepened, her nipples now undoubtedly stiff from her arousal, her goosebumps melting away.

"But he wants to give you the experiences you'd miss if you did only have him."

"And you still think he's lucky, wanting to do that?"

Jonah smiled, and gently kissed her lips. She really was so sweet. Like sugar. "I think if I were married, I would want a wife worth sharing."

His fingers slipped gently down her body, over her stomach, and then caressed her thigh as she uncrossed her legs for him, though keeping her left foot on the edge of the couch, her knee aloft.

Resting her head against his shoulder as she kissed him back, she heaved a huge sigh as his hand crept up to lodge between her hot thighs, touching the simple white cotton of her panties, discovering just how hot and wet she was down there already.

She moaned, and kissed him harder as his hand pressed against her sex, through her soaking underwear.

As he slipped his tongue inside her mouth, his fingers slipped under the sodden white cotton to seek out the blazing heat of her bare pussy. He was a little surprised to find she had shaved it completely this time.

"That's new," he said quietly, his hand gently exploring her smooth, hairless mound.

She smiled, "Richie helped me earlier. Said it turned him on, that I'd do this for another man. I don't know if I'd do it ordinarily."

"No?"

“But it made him so hard, I could see it excited him.”

“Do you like that?” he heard Emma’s voice in his ear again, but somehow it didn’t bother him as he thought it might. It was kind of sexy to think that another beautiful woman was watching him as he played with Bethany, and that perhaps she wanted him for herself.

“It’s beautiful,” he said. “I mean, I like a little fur down there as well... but...”

Stirring his fingers gently around her clit, without overwhelming her sensitive button too soon, drew out the kind of melodic moans that almost made him feel as though he were playing a musical instrument.

He pulled back from her, looking down at her body, and then between her legs even as he continued to touch her. A glance at her face, and her smile, and it was clear she knew he was simply being a cameraman for her husband. It was something he wouldn’t have to do if this was a normal date. But he felt obligated to Richie, for the gift of his wife but also the willingness for them to test this technology out in the field.

Bethany now pulled herself up, and out from his clutches, sinking down onto the floor.

“Stand up,” she urged him, and he did as she asked.

She shook her long hair so that it fell behind her shoulders, and knelt before him, her breasts hanging there so shapely, so stunning, her nipples so prominent.

Jonah removed his shirt while she unfastened his belt, then drew down his pants and boxer shorts.

“Mmmm...” she purred as she took hold of his big hard cock in her hand, stroking her hair out of her face with the other. “You know I’ve been thinking about this ever since the last time I saw it.”

“I’ll bet she has,” came Emma’s voice.

Jonah said, “I think my friend in my ear needs to keep quiet unless it’s really, really necessary.”

Bethany smiled and giggled again, but more flirty this time, rather than just nervous.

“Tell her Richie thinks she looks incredible, that she’s so sexy,” came Emma’s direction.

Jonah eye-rolled, which amused Bethany since she knew it was directed at Emma, but then said: “Your husband thinks you look incredible, you’re unbelievably sexy.”

She was blushing faintly as she looked up at Jonah’s face, up at those glasses and her husband’s view. Then a flicker of wickedness seemed to pass over her eyes, and she leaned in, closing her eyes as her lips parted to take the tip of Jonah’s cock inside her mouth.

She slid down on him as far as her fingers wrapped around his shaft, then withdrew before sinking down again, emitting a quiet moan that she was allowed this experience of new cock.

Jonah stroked her hair out of her face, and held it out of the way behind her head, not least so that her husband might see. He had to be careful to control himself, so that he didn’t finish too early, it was so hot penetrating her pretty face.

One thing he could not afford to do was to think about how Richie might be feeling, watching his wife doing this with another man. Even unmarried, the thought spurred Jonah’s own arousal further, particularly if he thought about certain women he might see in Bethany’s position. Emma, namely, though she was hardly one to be pinned down by marriage.

“You have such a nice cock,” Bethany said, wiping her mouth and laughing apparently at how much she liked it. “I always told myself I’d be happy with Richie’s and no others. And he has a very nice one. But I guess... it’s nice to enjoy others.”

“I’ll second that sentiment,” came Emma’s voice. Jonah felt himself throbbing in response to her saying that.

“Can you see everything?” Bethany whispered, and it seemed she wasn’t talking to Jonah.

“Everything,” Emma said.

Jonah nodded.

“I have the best husband in the world,” Bethany said, and sucked on Jonah as though she was experiencing the same kind of sensations as taking him inside her pussy.

“Richie wants you to go down on her,” Emma said, and he thought that perhaps the request wasn’t only from Richie.

“Is that right?” he asked.

“And I do, too,” admitted the blonde observer. God, at times he could hear her breathing. She was enjoying this, however good the picture was.

“Uh-huh,” said Bethany, answering his question though it was directed at Emma.

“Well,” he said, “let me show you what your husband wants for you now.”

He ushered her up, and guided her over to the bed. She was all wide-eyed, giddy excitement, and as she settled on the bed, so stunning against the white bedsheets, Jonah made sure her husband had a good view of her before it came time for the close-up.

“Take them off,” he said, eyeing her wet panties, which had already slipped down a fair way when she had shifted up on the bed.

She pulled them quickly off her legs, kicking them over to the floor. For a moment, he just left her there on the bed, propped up on her elbows, her thighs parted, glistening pussy revealed.

She was breathing hard, already.

He climbed onto the bed, between her legs, feeling her heat under him radiating up, even before he brushed against her warm, smooth body.

“Are you gonna fuck me?” she asked as his face moved up to hers.

“Because no one’s ever fucked me but Richie.”

“I will,” he said kissing her mouth, her cheek, her neck, “assuming your husband is fine with it.”

“I hope he is fine with it,” she said, gasping for breath as he kissed his way down her chest. She must have felt his erect cock brushing gently against her body as he hovered over her.

Jonah kissed his way around her flat, pale stomach, and then continued moving down to stroke his lips over her freshly shaven mound, inhaling the thicker scent of her arousal.

“Oh God,” she moaned as he kissed his way around her puffy red pussy lips, sampling hints of her savory goodness as he closed in on her prize.

She lay back against the mattress, closing her eyes as he slipped his tongue into her smoldering, soaking slit. Her whole body shook as he first penetrated her there, and oscillated as he parted her thighs further and sank his tongue as deep inside her as he could.

But then she pulled herself up again, leaning on an elbow before reaching down to steal the glasses from his face.

“Maybe I should wear them for a little while,” she said breathlessly.

Jonah had to admit, she probably could see a little more than the camera mounted on the glasses. The glasses themselves were getting a little steamed up between her thighs. He wasn’t going to stop her taking the glasses and putting them on herself.

“You look good in glasses,” he said, and thinking of Emma once again, added: “I definitely have a thing for girls in glasses.”

As Jonah resumed kissing Bethany’s pussy, and sucking on her tender folds, he looked up to see her gazing down on him.

And as Bethany sighed and panted while he licked and sucked on her sensitive sex, he heard the unmistakable sound of heavy breathing from his earpiece. Was Emma simply watching what was going on, or was she taking some kind of action?

Was she touching herself while she watched Jonah sucking on another woman’s clit? Wasn’t Richie in there with her, watching as she was?

Bethany's breathing accelerated into a little momentary peak of rapid fire, before easing into great long deep breaths interspersed with sexy little moans. He wasn't sure if she was having little climaxes, but it was some kind of cycle of pleasure she was going through.

She was struggling to keep her focus on what was going on, to keep her husband's view on this other man devouring her pussy, her natural inclination being to tilt her head backward to cope with the sensations flowing through her frame.

As she put her hand on his head, pressing him down against her, he thought she might be building up to something.

But she stopped him, urged him up, and breathless, said: "I'm ready."

Jonah pulled himself slowly up over her again, giving her husband time for any last-moment interjection.

Bethany was breathing hard, that anxious look back in her eyes as she touched his upper arms, and drew him in for a long kiss of the mouth. She sucked on his lips, her tongue forcing its way into his mouth, and he could see in the excitement rippling under the surface of her expression that she was desperate for this final crossing of the line.

She must have been thinking of this moment for a while.

Jonah heard an unmistakably breathless Emma whisper into his ear: "He's ready.

Her husband's ready."

Bethany could hear him listening to the voice in his ear, and he only had to nod to give her the answer she was looking for.

Jonah took the glasses from her, replacing them on his face so that her husband might witness for himself the reaction of his wife to her first penetration by a man other than her husband.

Underneath him, between her legs, he felt her fingers closing around his hardness, leading his hard tip to her hot, slippery entrance. She looked into his eyes, and for a moment seemed almost surprised, that it wasn't her husband staring back at her, perhaps.

“Fuck me, Jonah,” she said.

He squeezed his hips and entered her, easing slowly inside her tight, searing pussy.

“Oh God...” she whispered.

Her legs closed around his body as he slowly began to move inside her. She felt so good around him. Panting, gasping for oxygen as he thrust into her, she wanted to kiss him, and at the same time to look down, to see for herself this wicked connection between them—a breach of her wedding vows, even if it was with her husband’s consent.

He knelt up, and now placed a hand on her thigh to urge her over. Bethany did as he wanted, turning onto all fours in front of him, presenting her pale behind and that sweet pink pussy for his appreciation.

“You are so beautiful,” he said, ducking down to give her husband a thrill with a close view of her newly adulterous sex, before taking another brief taste of it himself.

Then with one hand on her lower back, he slid his hardness back inside her from behind, filling her completely, making her cry out.

There was definitely something appealing to the act of consorting with a woman promised to someone else. The way she responded to him, the delight in which all this gave her, it was good for a guy’s ego, certainly. No wonder Nate had gone in for this.

Bethany came hard as he fucked her, and Jonah thought that his job was probably made easier by the simple fact that he was only the second person ever

to be inside her.

She wasn’t done with that, however, leading him to turn over himself, lie on his back so that she could ride him, initially simply pressing herself down on his shaft, rocking back and forth on it, before steering it inside her again.

She rode him like a racehorse thundering down the final furlong, leaning back so that Jonah—and thereby her husband—had a sensational view of

her stunning pale body as the muscles in her thighs, her stomach and her chest flexed, her long hair swayed and her breasts shook.

He could crane his neck and see her pink flower swallowing his hardness again and again.

She was the picture of happiness and pure satisfaction, and Jonah could fully appreciate why her husband might want her to have this experience.

Only, as the time came, Jonah found himself wanting to have this experience from the other side of the fence, as the husband making the ultimate sexual gift to his sweet wife.

“Come inside me, come inside me, come inside me...” Bethany was whispering, leaning forward to hold him, to kiss him, to pull him over like some kind of wrestling move, so that he could pump her from on top, like some kind of animal.

But as the time came and he felt himself building to his own crescendo, more and more he focused on the voice in his ear, the deep breathing, the silky sighs, the unmistakable gasps.

“Oh Jesus... Oh Jesus... Oh God...”

As he filled Bethany with his adulterous seed, the orgasm rocking his body with a hell of a pulse, he heard the clear sounds of Emma coming along with them, crying out as her own climax hit.

And the sense that she could have been making love to Richie at that point, the flicker of jealousy it provoked, only made him come harder inside the man’s wife.

Six

Afterwards, they both just lay back on the bed, out of breath, a little dazed at the power of the orgasms that had gone through them both.

Bethany, all red-faced, looking over to Jonah as though not quite believing she’d just had sex with a relative stranger, a man who was not her husband. The second man ever.

“That was amazing,” she said. “That was seriously amazing.”

“Wasn’t it?”

Jonah smiled, acting as though for him, it had been incredible just being with Bethany. It probably would have if he had been, but the power of his climax came from the fact that he’d heard Emma coming at the same time as Bethany.

The freshly defiled young wife pushed herself up on her elbows and shook out her hair.

“I think my husband will be wanting me to go home with him,” she said apologetically.

Jonah let out a little groan as though remembering their sex, though in reality he was imagining how he might feel to be Bethany’s husband just now. To get her back, sullied from sleeping with another man, so beautiful in her wickedness, her depravity.

Ripe to be reclaimed.

“He’s probably raring to go,” he said to her as she knelt up, ran her fingers through her mussed, perspiration-enhanced hair, and then over her breasts.

“I’m sorry to be so rude in leaving like this...” she smiled.

“Go, go,” Jonah said, magnanimous. “You’re only halfway through the experience.”

“Okay,” she sighed, and pulled herself off the bed, heading for the bathroom, adding breathlessly, “Oh my God...”

She changed in the bathroom, though Jonah did not hear running water, and she certainly did not shower. Fresh from the experience, then. Somehow it made Jonah tremble a little, and when she emerged from the en suite again, in that bright red dress of hers, her black top unfastened enough to show the upper slopes of her cleavage, her just-fucked ambience made him feel positively weak at the knees.

Her husband was going to have an incredible time as soon as he got her back.

“You going to see me out?” she joked, since Jonah was still naked other than a pair of boxer shorts he’d donned while she had been dressing in the bathroom.

“Sure,” he said, perhaps missing her joke, though he did escort her to the door.

She leaned in to kiss him one last time as they parted at the door. “Have a good night with Emma,” she said, and he felt a tingle at the reminder that Emma would, indeed, be paying a visit soon.

“Have a great night with Richie,” he returned.

“Oh, I will. I’ve had lessons.”

“From me?”

“Of course! Who else?”

“Well, it was a pleasure to teach you.”

“A bientôt,” she said, then with a girlish giggle, she opened the door.

Emma was there, of course, holding out a key card for another room—the room she had been watching from, and where Richie no doubt was now waiting. The two young women gave each other wicked, knowing smiles at what was awaiting each other.

Jonah took a step back, wondering if perhaps he needed a longer break before facing the challenge of his horny blonde assistant-with-benefits. He wasn’t exactly as young as Richie and Bethany.

But after stepping inside the room, dropping her bag and allowing the heavy door to click shut behind her, she pounced on him. He had only enough time to brace himself before catching her, her arms flung around his neck, her thighs clamped around his hips, her lips pressed against his for a passionate kiss.

She filled his senses with her characteristic sweet coconut, but as she clung to him, he was aware of the lingering smells of sex about himself, the traces of Bethany.

“I should shower,” he said. “At least rinse off.”

“Don’t you dare.”

She kissed him again, standing this time, letting his hands roam over her body rather than be forced to hold her up.

“You know most women would want me to shower before they got into anything,” he said.

She gave him a mischievous grin. “Oh, and most women would watch their man sleep with another woman and get off on it?”

“I suppose not,” he said.

She was sucking on his lips, had to be tasting the other woman as she did so.

“You really like that you can detect her on me?” he asked, genuinely curious.

Emma shrugged, “It’s a little bit sexy, isn’t it?”

He slipped the strap of her white top off over her shoulder, revealing one of her breasts—she was not wearing a bra. If she’d slept with another man, and he was allowed to watch, would he want to experience her afterwards as she was?

He felt a little shiver course through him at the thought of Emma being manhandled, of being fucked by someone else. Perhaps that feeling of wrongness, the spiciness of taboo sex, would be enhanced by detecting another man’s scent on her.

It would prove how naughty she was.

“I guess so,” he said, marveling at how hard her nipple was before he enveloped it in his hand, and she pulled him back in for another kiss.

“I like being naughty,” she said when the kiss came to its conclusion. “And I like letting you be naughty.”

He kissed her breast, took her nipple in his hot mouth.

“I like giving you the treat, and then indulging in you after,” she said, and then sank down, running her face down his chest and breathing in deeply as she did so, inhaling the aroma that clung to him still.

“I like knowing what a bad boy you were,” she said, breathing him in, her hands cupping his hardness through his underwear. “I like knowing you had her, but now you’re mine.”

She went down on her knees, stroking his burgeoning erection and surroundings with both hands, then drew his boxer shorts down his thighs, releasing his cock.

It was still sticky from another woman, and yet she took it in one hand, and then the other, beaming as she caressed his shaft, putting it to her nose before breathing in a great long breath.

She licked him, tasting another woman’s juices as she ran her tongue along the underside of his shaft. And then she slipped his tip inside her mouth, not at all squeamish.

“You’re wearing glasses,” he said, a little surprised he hadn’t noticed until she was kneeling there, her lips wrapped around his cock.

“I heard you had a thing for girls in glasses,” she grinned.

He really did like her wearing them. Somehow they emphasized her intelligence, and even drew attention to just how pretty she was.

It felt incredible as she sank on him, and withdrew, sank then withdrew, her body rising and falling each time as she knelt there, one hand clutched around the base of his shaft, the other gripping his behind.

What if she’d been doing this to another man—to Clement, say. And then fucking him. Would he be squeamish about sleeping with her afterwards?

When she rose to her feet again, he was aware of where her mouth had just been when she neared him for another kiss. Could he taste himself on her? Not really.

Perhaps if he imagined it.

“So you could see everything all right?” he asked her. “When I was with Bethany?”

She nodded. “It was a great view. Those cameras might be tiny, but they’re high definition. Wanna see?”

“Sure,” he laughed. “I still don’t know where you found them.”

A shrug, “The Internet. You can get everything there.”

She stood up, and retrieved her bag. He found himself a seat on the edge of the bed, looking at the large blank TV screen opposite.

Emma stood in front of him, wiggling her hips suggestively as she drew an iPad out of her bag, before jettisoning the bag itself.

“You just want to see Bethany again, don’t you?” she teased him.

“Well she was beautiful, wasn’t she?” he said, leaning forward, his hands moving around to grab her by the waist and pull her to him.

“Hey, wait up!” she squealed, “If you want to see her, I have to figure this out.”

She flipped the television on with its black plastic remote, then stood there fiddling with her iPad as the hotel welcome message played on the large screen.

Jonah was feeling tempted, even if he had his doubts about his own performance so soon after sleeping with another woman. He pulled her closer to him again, this time his hands reaching around her waist to seek out the fly on her jeans.

She seemed happy enough for him to unfasten them, then drag them down her legs. Even stepped out of them for him, leaving her standing there in her white tank top and a white satin g-string that showed off the shape of her behind to glorious effect.

She also didn’t stop him as he slumped down onto the floor, and kissed his way around her cute butt and slender thighs until he sat in front of her, gazing up at her stunning body and the strong allure of her white satin-covered mound.

“You don’t need any wires or anything?” he asked her, kissing his way up one of her thighs, breathing in that dark, spicy scent of her arousal, so thick after her little voyeuristic thrill next door.

“Oh no, it should all connect up wirelessly,” she said. “I’m just trying to get the app working—you never know exactly what kind of TV you’re going to get in a hotel like this... Oh God...”

His mouth had found its way up to her sex, tasting her, tonguing her through her underwear.

She didn’t stop him as he slipped aside her panties, and traced the tip of his tongue up through her little red slit to its apex, and her clit, either.

God, she tasted divine.

She just left him to it for a few moments, though she edged her legs open a little wider to allow him easier access. Then he heard familiar sounds coming from the TV immediately behind him—the voice of Bethany telling him he looked good in those glasses.

Emma dropped the iPad onto the table in front of the TV, and now slid her fingers through his hair, stroking him for encouragement initially, before her hand closed and she was grabbing his head forcefully, controlling where he was licking.

He liked her forcefulness.

As he sucked on her pussy, and lapped at her free-flowing juices, she said:

“Don’t you want to see how the video came out? How you look with Bethany?”

“I can wait,” he said, pressing himself into her as much as possible, penetrating her with his tongue.

He loved being so intimate with her sex. It had been enjoyable with each woman he’d been with, but it was extra special with Emma. Perhaps because it seemed extra special making her feel good.

She was holding his head with both hands now, riding his face as she watched the scene on the television. She was so wet, she tasted so fine. Her flavor was stronger than Bethany's, he thought, as was her scent, and seemed to drive him wilder. It could have been because she'd already come that night, she'd been toying with herself while watching him with Bethany.

For a moment, he broke away, turned to see that Emma was watching the scene in which he had done this to Bethany, although that particular time Bethany had been lying on the bed.

He said: "When you were watching with Richie, were you..."

She looked down at him and smiled, "Of course, couldn't you hear me through that earpiece?"

"But Richie was there in the room?"

"He was doing it too."

He felt a tickle of jealousy just then, unexpectedly strong.

"And he saw you?" he asked, his voice sounding perhaps a touch sharper than he entirely meant.

She said, "I don't really think so. He was sitting on the bed, right in front of the TV, totally absorbed by it. I was sitting further back, in the armchair."

"But he knew you were doing it?"

She shrugged, "I don't know. He never turned to look round at me, not once.

And it wasn't as though he'd see a huge amount—just a girl with her hand down the front of her pants."

"You could see him? I mean his..."

That was the thing, wasn't it? The thing that really stirred the butterflies in his stomach—the thought of her seeing another man's hard cock, perhaps desiring it.

“From time to time,” she said. “Does that bother you?”

He felt himself blushing. What right did he have to say it did? They weren’t exclusive. And did it entirely bother him? He was harder than ever for hearing it.

“Uh... no,” he said.

She nodded, but he couldn’t quite read her expression from there on the floor.

Disappointed? Ambivalent? Thankful he wasn’t actively upset at her?

She pushed him away, and sank into a crouch, her hands on his shoulders, her lips closing in on his for a kiss that would share her flavor.

“You don’t have anything to worry about,” she said. “I think yours is nicer.”

“Thank you.”

“I mean, Richie’s a nice guy and everything, but... well, Bethany must have enjoyed her first time being unfaithful, if you get my meaning.”

She sucked gently on his top lip, and then his bottom lip, slipping the tip of her tongue in to graze over his. One of Jonah’s hands was resting by her inner thigh, so it seemed natural to bring it up, slip it inside her sodden panties, seek out the centre of her heat and her wetness.

She turned her head, smiling broadly as his finger slid inside her. He kissed her cheek, her neck, curious in that moment how Richie was feeling about doing this kind of thing with Bethany, now that she had officially crossed the line, breached their marital vows.

How would he feel holding Emma in his arms after she had been with another?

But now Emma urged him up, peeling off her white top to reveal her sweet breasts. Her panties came down with barely more than a slight tug.

Then with a mischievous smirk, she led him over to the bed holding his manhood, releasing him only as she climbed onto the mattress, turning

onto her back, ready for him.

“So this is how it’s going to be on all my dates now?” he asked her, crawling up beside and a little over her, one knee between her thighs, his leg pressing up against her wet pussy.

“Uh-huh?”

“I’ll have you watching every move I make?”

She turned her head so he could kiss her neck, but then he was moving slowly down the low rise of her small but sweet breasts, to the smooth concave slope from her ribcage down to her stomach.

“Better believe it,” she sighed as the gentle roughness of his chest hair brushed over her sensitive sex.

“I think we’ll have to maintain radio silence when things are actually happening,” he said.

“Radio silence?”

He kissed over her abdomen, and over to the side, and the slight ridge of her pelvis, before running his lips lightly over the soft sprinkling of golden hair over her mound.

“Much as I loved hearing you... enjoying yourself... while I was with Bethany,”

he said, making her laugh, “it was quite distracting at times. Never mind your commentary.”

“I’m sorry,” she said. “I wasn’t expecting to find it quite so... hot. Actually watching you with her, I mean.”

“What, you’d seen me with Kaia, right?”

“Yes, but that’s Kaia. This was something different.”

“Different how?”

Hands underneath her, supporting her lower back, his arms curling under her thighs, Jonah dipped his tongue inside her slick, smoldering groove, sampling her nectar once more.

She closed her eyes and quietly gasped, her arms folded behind her head, her nipples so hard as her chest began to rise and fall in a deeper, heavier rhythm.

“I don’t know...” she said after a moment or two, “but seeing you with Kaia was nice. Seeing you with Bethany was insane.”

“Insane?” he pressed his mouth and nose into her pussy, drawing out a long moan as he gently sucked on her slippery lips.

“Oh God...” she said, but then held up her head to watch him, trying to control her response to him. “When you were with her, it was like I was terrified the whole time—and yet at the same time it was so exciting.”

“Terrified?”

“I don’t know why. I guess afraid that I’d lose you... as a... you know, friend.”

Jonah felt a touch disappointed, that she described him only as a “friend”. But what else was she going to do? She wasn’t the type to settle down with a boyfriend. He had to get used to it.

“You won’t lose me as a friend, no matter what happens,” he said, loving how her hips were moving to the rhythm of his licking.

“I know that. It’s just my paranoid subconscious. I just have to ignore it.” She sighed, then, “I promise I’ll be quiet in future, when I’m watching your dates.”

He smiled, and now trailed the tip of his tongue up over her mound, her stomach, between her ribs and her breasts, up her neck and over her chin to return to her mouth.

“Good,” he said, kissing her mouth briefly. “So when’s the next date?”

“Well the woman you favorited this morning can see you tomorrow night if you’d like. Or Thursday.”

He pushed himself up so that he was sitting on his haunches, his cock in one hand, sliding it around her open petals.

“Tomorrow night, huh? I think Thursday might be better. I’m going to need a rest after tonight.”

She smiled, her hips stirring again, almost begging him to slot himself inside her.

“A rest? Well you better earn yourself a rest, mister.”

He dipped his tip inside her, and watched her open her mouth and groan. For her, the evening had been a long wait for this moment.

“I’ll earn it,” he said, pushing himself forward, into her, filling her completely, as she craned her neck slightly to watch an image of his earlier self filling another woman entirely.



That night, Jonah felt too buzzed from his evening to sleep. The two of them lay awake a while in the darkness of that hotel room, Emma messing about on her laptop, Jonah bringing her up to date on everything he knew, everything he’d found at Lady Moss’s house.

“She is totally banging that butler,” she said of his observations of Reynolds, Lady Moss’s help.

“That’s the impression I got.”

“I would, probably, if I was her. Especially if my husband was murdered.”

“She was probably sleeping with him before her husband passed away, too,”

Jonah said. “I got the impression he’d been with her long enough.”

“And her husband probably watched.”

She sighed. "Sometimes I wish I had a husband who'd love me like that."

"Like that?"

"You know, like Richie and Bethany."

"I didn't think you were interested in a husband," Jonah said.

She looked at him, and for a moment seemed suddenly anxious. "Oh no," she said. "There's plenty of time for all that. I'm just saying... you know... when I get married, I want my husband to love me enough to... you know..."

"To let you keep on sleeping around."

"Exactly."

"You know," Jonah said, but was then cut off by the trill of a mobile phone.

It took a moment for him to recognize the rare sound of his own phone, and then a few more to actually locate the damn thing.

"Who would be calling me this late?" he muttered as he finally found it on the

floor by the bathroom. "You see why I think mobile phones are a bad idea?"

Emma stuck her tongue out at him. "They're such a bad idea, how else would you have found the restaurant tonight without one?" she said. "Your whole evening of sex and debauchery was totally reliant on mobile phone technology."

"I suppose," he said, finally tracking down the phone. He didn't recognize the number. "Hello?"

"Jonah? It's me."

Lily. He looked across at Emma's inquisitive face, and knew instantly he didn't want to be talking to Lily just now.

“I couldn’t work out the number.”

“I’m calling from a phone booth. You know how those newspapers hack in to people’s phones...”

“And you don’t imagine they could hack into mine?”

“Well, it doesn’t matter. They’re here now. Outside—not going to leave me alone no matter what I do, I imagine.”

“They’re outside your house?”

“Like a pack of mangy hyenas waiting for some poor gazelle to drop dead,” she said. “Been out there all day.”

Jonah wondered if any reporters were staking out Nate’s apartment building yet.

Perhaps they were watching from the other side of the North Dock, hidden away in the building at 10 Cabot Square.

“Are you okay?” he asked. Emma was looking at him with a big question on her face. She mouthed the words: who is it? He signaled that it was nothing, that he’d tell her in a minute.

“I’m as okay as anyone would be, I suppose,” said Lily, “locked up under some kind of house arrest, for no reason.”

“Aaron okay?”

“A little bewildered by it all. Couldn’t understand why I didn’t take him to nursery this morning. Have you had anyone outside your building?”

“Not that I can see,” he said, not really wanting to tell her he was safely secreted away in a hotel room after a date. “Look, I’m sure we just have to wait it out—

hope that it blows over. They’ll have to go away when they see nothing’s happening.”

“That’s usually only when they start making things up,” she said. “Look, there was one of them... came up to me in the supermarket while I was

buying apples.

Said you'd vouch for him."

"A journalist?"

"A journalist. Red hair, pale kind of guy..."

Keeley. Well, he had said to him that he'd try and talk to Lily to get her to give him some time.

"Keeley, I think his name is. Harold Keeley. Writes for the Guardian." Or so he said.

"And he's... okay?" He could hear a tremor in her voice just then, as though she was cold. "Only, the Guardian might seem like a nice cozy paper for lefties, but I know some of their reporters, and they're not so nice."

"I think he's okay," Jonah said, feeling as though he was taking something of a risk in endorsing the man. "I think he's on our side."

"He said if I talked to him, he could help us."

"He might be able to, yes."

She drew in her breath, said: "Well I hope he can. If this doesn't work out, I'll go and live on an island somewhere."

"Right."

"And you better come visit me if you do, Mister, 'cause you're partly to blame for all this."

"I'm to blame?"

She laughed, and just hearing her like that warmed him up inside. "Well, you made me seduce you, didn't you?"

When he hung up the phone, Emma was looking at him with a face like thunder.

She'd worked out who he'd been talking to, of course. Could probably just about hear from there that it was someone female.

"What did she want? To see you again?" she asked him. He felt touched that she'd be jealous, but also somewhat confused. Kaia had said she wasn't the type to want commitment. With all the women he'd seen—and that included Bethany, with whom their few dates had prompted more affection than simple one night stands—why was she so against him seeing Lily?

"No," he said, perhaps fudging the truth a little. "She's just being hassled by the media. I guess it might happen to me soon, too. The papers just want to write anything they can about the Black Widow murders, from whatever angle."

"I don't like her," Emma said, bluntly earnest. "I don't want you seeing her."

"Come here," he said, diving back onto the bed, dragging her to him like a ravenous lion pulling in a startled antelope.

She giggled as he pressed his hardness against her behind. "Hey," she said as he slid inside her once again, "you're going to have to get some sleep, Mister. You have another date coming up soon enough, remember?"

Seven

Why was he more nervous about the dates where he met the woman in a hotel room—without all the meandering about over dinner or drinks at a bar?

Somehow, it felt more serious. These were women who meant business, knew what they wanted and went out and got it. They were not beginners.

Or maybe it was the fact that this was his first new encounter since Emma and Kaia's staged attack.

"Okay, you all set?"

"It feels funny, wearing glasses."

Emma said, “There’s no alternative, really. Not if you want to guarantee it’ll work. If you had a separate camera, you might not get to position it properly.”

He nodded. It felt funny wearing a designer business suit, too, but he wasn’t going to mention that. At least he wasn’t wearing a tie—the open-necked shirt thing being suitably contemporary for City folk, according to Emma. She looked as smart as he did, in a shimmering black dress made with billions of sequins.

They looked like a couple on the way to a ballroom dance—appropriate for a five-star hotel like this one.

“You’ll be able to pick up the signal?”

“I’ll find somewhere to lurk, don’t worry. It’ll work as long if I’m on the same floor, definitely.”

The elevator only had to climb seven floors, but it was slow. Guests of this particular hotel—the Marriott Park Lane, just a stone’s throw from the Marble Arch on the corner of Oxford Street and Park Lane—clearly had time on their hands.

“Okay, but tell me if you can’t.”

Emma grinned, “Thought you wanted radio silence?”

He rolled his eyes. “Unless there’s an emergency. Your inability to watch constitutes an emergency, doesn’t it? Since you wouldn’t be able to help in case something happens.”

“It’ll be fine. I’ll find somewhere on this floor,” she said as they finally reached level seven. “Even if I have to knock on someone’s door and offer to sleep with them.”

He laughed with her at that, though it reminded him that at some point soon, she would be going out for another date with Clement, Martin Sallow’s best friend.

“It might be too early for anyone else to be in their rooms anyway—it’s dinner time,” he said. “Sorry to disappoint you if you were hoping for a stranger’s bed.”

She grinned. “You just want to keep me to yourself, don’t you?”

Their smiles faded as they stepped out into another finely decorated hallway in a hotel Jonah could not afford. This was a serious business now. The woman he was meeting was a step up in terms of the likelihood that she was a killer. She had, after all, been on Nate’s favorites list. His late brother had put her on the list of possible dates, and as happened with Jonah, simply putting her on that list might have prompted her to ask Nate out for a one night stand like this one.

“Okay,” Emma whispered. “Have a good time, right? Even if you’re working.”

She smiled at that. He returned her smile, although he could have argued with her that this was more than just sleeping with some random stranger. He had to focus, had to concentrate. Had to take a particular kind of care—else his life could be forfeit.

Then he rounded a corner, and there was the door to room 723. Emma stopped right there, so that if anyone was looking through the peephole, they’d only see Jonah. She offered him a silent wave and a good luck as he briefly glanced back, and she held up her iPad to indicate she’d be watching him.

Finally, she drew a thumb and forefinger across her lips to indicate that she would remain silent during his date. She would not distract him.

He was shaking a little as he knocked on the door. He had to try to control that, although it was perfectly reasonable to expect even a City boy to be mildly nervous when going out on a sex date with a woman he’d never met before. He was fairly certain this date was a cut above all his previous ones in its importance.



“Hi. Robert?”

“Yes. Gemma, right?”

“Right.”

She leaned in to kiss his cheek, and he was immediately surprised by her height.

She had two, or perhaps three inches on him. As pretty as her photograph, though: she was no disappointment. She had vibrant coppery hair dropping down to her shoulders, an almost feline face, her lips painted scarlet and her eyes accented with eyeliner and dark lashes.

“Good to meet you,” he said.

“And you, you come well recommended.”

He smiled, guessing that she’d seen his statistics.

She was wearing a leather jacket over a dark blue lace dress that dropped down to mid-thigh. From her jacket, she produced a small piece of paper, which she handed to him. Jonah knew well enough what to give her in return. It was so much like getting the business out of the way at the start of a genuine instance of prostitution, but it was the general rule.

Her medical certificate seemed legitimate, so that was that.

When he looked up at her, she was peering closely at his face, rather than his own medical certificate. It sent a chill down his spine: was she surprised to find him wearing glasses all of a sudden, when his profile picture had none?

But she didn’t say anything about them.

“Okay,” she said, offering him the kind of smile that acknowledged but also played down the slight weirdness of having to scrutinize each others’ medical check-up. “Come on through.”

It wasn’t perhaps quite as grand as the rooms at the Savoy, but it was a level above any hotel Jonah could afford to stay in—a nice suite with quality

furniture, decorated in an understated, minimalist style that still presented a cozy atmosphere thanks to the use of warm floor lamps.

He removed his jacket, hung it in the wardrobe by the door, then went through with her to find an armchair. Gemma perched opposite him, on a

stippled gray couch, and Jonah had no idea what she had in mind.

“You live locally, Robert?”

“Not too far away—Docklands,” he said.

“Impressive,” she smiled. “You work out that way?”

He shared her smile, “I guess I’m not supposed to really tell you I’m a trader in the City.”

“Yes, that’s what they say, isn’t it? Don’t tell your date personal information, like where you work.”

“And you?” he asked, since they were already breaking rules.

“Oh, mainly I support my husband’s work these days,” she said with a knowing look that said she wasn’t going to open up about what her husband did. “But I do a little design now and then.”

“Design?”

“Clothes, mostly.”

“Impressive.”

She smiled, revealing even white teeth and dimples in her cheeks, and not for the first time Jonah felt strange being presented with such a woman, with the knowledge that he was here to have sex with her.

Twenty-first century dating was certainly a brave new world.

“So,” she said, taking on a sudden change of tone. Businesslike. “You said in your messages you would be okay with... well, with being watched.”

“Yes,” he said, swallowing involuntarily. “I did. But you mentioned that he

wouldn’t be in the room, right?”

“Right,” she nodded. “He’s traveling just now. On the other side of the world, actually. Singapore.”

“Okay.”

“That’s why I asked you here so early. It’s 1am over there at the moment.”

“You have a camera?”

“A few,” she nodded, her eyes flicking around the room. He glanced, but only spotted the obvious one by the large television, on the table at the end of the bed.

So, there would be more cameras in the room than just the one in his glasses. But he’d done this before, with Richie and Emma watching.

He was still a little nervous about it.

“Don’t worry, I don’t bite,” she smiled, perhaps reading the uncertain expression on his face. “Unless you’d like me to, of course.”

“Right.”

“I’m just going to use the bathroom,” she said. “I just need to get through to my husband.”

He nodded, and she stood, once again impressing him with her height as she went through to the en suite, and closed the door.

Presumably they’d done this before, she seemed too confident for it to be a first time. But he’d noticed a hint of nerves in her, too, he was sure of it. And having to talk to her husband in private before going through with this... well, even after they’d done it a few times, they still needed to reassure each other, it seemed.

Speaking of reassurance... Jonah drew his phone out of his pocket.

He tapped out a quick text and sent it to Emma.

>You in position? Everything working okay?

When she replied, she spoke quietly through his earpiece, and it quite startled him to hear her right there in his ear. “Everything’s fine,” she said. “A lovely young guy with a big cock has let me hang out in his room.”

Jonah silently gasped, but then he heard her laugh, “Only kidding. I’m sitting on the stairs round the corner from you. Think it’s like the fire exit, nobody will be using it. So you’re okay?”

He didn’t have time to text her back, since the door to the bathroom was opening with Gemma on her way back out. But, since he knew Emma was watching via the camera in his glasses, he gave her a quick thumbs up to indicate his state of mind.

Gemma returned minus her leather jacket. She did look good in that dress. It clung to her hourglass figure, seemed to push up her bust to emphasize her cleavage, revealed her long, smooth legs to full effect.

“Okay, he’ll be watching in five minutes or so,” she said.

“Great,” Jonah smiled, feeling the butterflies fluttering in his stomach. He felt a little added pressure now, a little more anxiety that things would go wrong, that the husband would start watching and he would fail to perform.

“So,” she smiled, taking her seat opposite him on the sofa. “You’re okay with him watching?”

“Of course,” he said, a little more confidently than he felt.

“If it’s okay with you, I’ll go back in there to change—he likes watching me getting ready for my dates.”

“Sure, okay.”

“Do you like a dominant woman, Robert?” she asked, her smile still there, but her eyes flashing intent, and a powerful energy that stirred Jonah a little.

“I do,” he said.

“I mean, I know you’re a City boy, and you’re never sure if City boys can handle a real woman.”

“Oh, I can.”

“That’s what I’m led to believe,” she nodded. “I checked your references.”

“My references?”

She laughed, “A real woman can’t find the right guy just off his star ratings, you know. But you’ve already been tried and tested by someone in my network.”

Network? Jonah nodded, but didn’t probe further, not wanting to come across as a lightweight.

“So,” she patted her knees as though the contract was signed and sealed, then stood up. “I’ll be back out in a few moments,” she said, and he watched her return to the bathroom.

He fired off another text message to Emma while he waited.

> You get all that? Husband likes to watch her getting ready for her dates.

Emma replied verbally: “Kinky. So you were recommended to her through her network? That’s interesting. I guess website users are free to communicate between each other even if they’re not actively dating.”

Jonah heard the sound of Gemma’s voice in the bathroom, though he couldn’t make out what she was saying over the sound of running water. She was talking to her husband.

It gave him time to carry out a quick search of the room. Maybe it was a little obvious, but if she was the killer, she’d hardly leave her knife lying around, would she?

But then the Black Widow didn’t always use a knife, did she? Julian Foster was strangled. The latest victim was poisoned, wasn’t he?

There were no signs of anything out of the ordinary that Jonah could see.

Nothing in any drawers other than the standard Gideon Bible, nothing in the closet save for an overnight bag, and a quick rifle through that turned up nothing unexpected.

Emma's voice came through the earpiece again: "Nothing seems out of the ordinary, but keep alert. You run out of there the moment you see anything even remotely suspicious. Even if you're naked."

Jonah smiled. He texted her:

> You just want to see me run out of the hotel naked, huh?

She replied, "You could always just do it anyway, even if there's no danger at all."

Then the door to the en suite opened again, and Jonah stashed the phone away.

When Gemma came back out of the bathroom, the dress was gone and she was wearing black lace bra and panties, and black lace-top stockings, along with a pair of high heels. It looked sensational on her, against her pale skin and that shock of bright red hair.

She walked slowly up to him.

"Stand up," she said.

He did as he was told. In her heels, she towered over him. Wow. Jessica had been dominant, but she hadn't had quite such a presence.

"Show it to me," she said, pulling him to her by the belt.

Jonah unfastened his belt, and as he drew his pants down his legs, Gemma stepped up to him, her hands reaching to touch his face, and curl around the back of his head, then she pushed her body close to him, her breasts particularly prominent under his gaze, and her closeness swamped him with her warm, oriental fragrance.

His underwear went down with his suit pants, leaving him feeling exposed, vulnerable.

Her right hand dropped, her fingers curling around his shaft, stroking him.

“Very nice,” she said. “I guess you pass the test. Take off your shirt.”

He complied.

As she ran her other hand over his shirt, she gently rubbed the tip of his cock over her panties, and the lace tops of her stockings.

“You like fucking other men’s wives?” she asked him, moving in as though to kiss his mouth, but then turning her head so that he was presented only with her pale neck.

“Yes, Miss,” he said.

As he kissed her neck, she took a deep breath in, and both her hands began manhandling his cock.

“And why’s that? You’re attractive, you have a high-paid job in the City, you could get any single girl you wanted.”

He groaned as she pumped him, as he inhaled her beguiling scent from her upper chest. “Married women are like forbidden fruit,” he said, suddenly thinking about how he felt about Bethany, sweet Bethany, who had never had any other man but her husband, and apparently wanted to sleep with Jonah.

He kissed the slopes of her large breasts, and felt one of her hands on the back of his head again, this time pressing him down into the valley of her cleavage.

She was so warm, her unusual perfume really giving him the tingles inside.

So she had some kind of network through the website. Well, Julian Foster had been communicating with other members of No Strings, without taking them out on dates. So it must have been possible for women to email each other and ask who they’d already dated, and who they had already enjoyed.

Who was it that had recommended him to Gemma? Jessica? Gabriella?

Gemma knelt in front of him, and looked up at his face while she traced her tongue up from the base to the tip of his erect cock. Then she took him inside her mouth, crushing him with her tongue, her cheeks and her lips. Almost consuming him.

Her position was hardly dominant, but the way she used his cock, the way she

licked him and sucked him, the way she looked up at him, somehow she made it seem as though this was all for her. She liked the feel of a man's cock in her mouth, and she was going to take it from him.

"Does it feel good being used by a woman?" she asked him. "Being a woman's personal play-thing?"

"Yes, Miss," he said, trying not to wince as she pumped him a little hard in her hands.

She slipped her breasts out of the cups of her bra, and said: "You can touch them if you like."

He didn't take it as optional, fondling her, squeezing her hard nipples while she continued to stroke his stiffness.

She moaned, and then took over control of her chest, lodging his hardness in the soft, hot vale between her breasts, then began rocking back and forth.

Jonah let out a long, deep groan and stirred his hips, fucking her cleavage.

"Don't get too excited," she warned, and he halted his own movement. "You don't want to come early, do you? Sit down."

He sat in the armchair, his bare butt feeling a little wrong there, naked on the hotel's nice furniture. She pushed him back and draped herself over him, her breasts grazing over his hard cock, her body rubbing over him, up and down, allowing her to take his cock briefly back inside her mouth now and again.

It seemed to Jonah almost that she was teasing her husband by doing this: rubbing as much of her body on this strange cock as she could, marking herself with it.

She stood, but leaned over him, offering a superlative view of her breasts, then ducked down to briefly kiss his mouth.

Straightening up, she said: “Really, you should be pleasuring me, Robert. Don’t you think?”

“Yes, Miss.”

“Down, boy.”

She pointed, and Jonah went down onto the carpet. Submissive, respectful, worshipful.

Gemma turned her back to him leaning over the armchair, pushing out her behind. He kissed her round cheeks, running his hands up her nylon stockings.

She smiled, and flicked her thumbs into the waistband of her panties to draw them down her thighs. Pushing up her butt further, she revealed her pussy in all its glory.

He kissed his way along the lace tops of her stockings, then over her bare flesh, breathing in her strong scent. Then he was licking her wet slit, making her sigh, making her groan, making her bite her lip. Serving her.

Her pussy was shaven, though she had a coppery bush over her mound. Her flavor was strong, salty, earthy. Somehow more intense than other women he’d known. If she was an accustomed taste, though, he became accustomed fairly quickly.

He loved to make her moan. Wasn’t that something about a dominant woman? It seemed more like an achievement to actually give her pleasure.

After a while, she looked back at him, said simply: “Fuck me, now. Like this.”

He pulled himself up, erect cock in hand, touched it to the searing heat of her pussy before pushing forward, gliding into her. No nonsense, no messing about.

Exactly what she wanted.

“Oof,” she grunted as he filled her, moving easily inside her seriously wet pussy.

Was Emma watching this? He was still wearing the glasses, so she must have been. Hoping no one was coming up or down that staircase while she watched...

Then as he started thrusting into the redhead, she yelled: “Fuck me... fuck me...”

He saw her hand tucked between her legs, touching her clit as he slammed into her, but as he stepped up his pace, battering her round butt so that it quivered with each blow, her coppery hair swaying with each strike, she had to hold

herself with both hands, yelling with each thrust.

“Oh fuck, honey...” she said, and it took a moment for him to realize she wasn’t talking to him. “Oh fuck, he’s good, honey... Really good...”

But she wasn’t done with him yet. She pushed herself up, extending her arms, so she could turn her head and kiss his mouth.

“The bed,” she said to him, breathless. “You can fuck me properly.”

He stepped back, catching his breath himself, letting her up from the chair. She removed her panties completely, leaving them where they fell, then walked confidently up to him, grabbing him by the cock.

“Come,” she smiled, giving him a tug before turning to walk purposefully to the bed.

She sprawled over the white bedsheets, and told him to remove her shoes. He did so, like some kind of valet, then held her stocking-clad foot, kissed her arch.

She touched herself, her fingers flickering rapidly over her pussy, as he kissed his way slowly up her legs. As he reached the soft pale flesh of her upper thighs, however, drawing tantalizingly close to her sex, so that he noticed how rosy red it was against the stark white of her skin, she shook her head.

The air was thick with the scent of her arousal, but she was going to deny him another taste, it seemed. He was disappointed.

“Lie down,” she ordered him. He complied, pulling himself up on the bed, and turning onto his back. “You’re my toy to do with as I please,” she said by way of explanation, as though he needed it.

“Yes, Miss.”

She knelt over him from the side, hand closing around his shaft, squeezing him, pumping him a little too hard for comfort, licking him though not for his pleasure.

Then she lifted her stocking-clad leg, straddling him, facing away from his head, her fingers tilting his hardness to her sex, so she could sink down on him.

“Oh yeah...” she breathed, Jonah pumping his hips up to meet her as she sank on him, no doubt offering her husband a superlative view.

“Fuck me... fuck me...”

She let out a long howling cry, her whole body shaking as Jonah took on most of the effort of slamming his cock inside her. He could see she was playing with her clit again while he fucked her, her voice becoming sing-song, perhaps a touch exaggerated for the benefit of her audience, perhaps not. Perhaps she came.

Then she fell on him, pressing him down, taking back control and slowing the pace right down as she leaned forward, toward the camera and away from Jonah’s gaze, giving him a superb view of his cock sinking into her pussy, splitting her round behind.

How must the husband be feeling about this, watching it all on a screen thousands of miles away?

She fondled her breasts, looking down between her legs, at his cock sliding in and out of her pussy.

“Oh God, honey,” she said, looking at the camera, “I came so hard. He made me come so fucking hard...”

She laughed, then dismounted, lay over him to the side, grabbing his cock, shoving it back in her mouth, “Isn’t it the most beautiful cock you ever saw?”

she said again to the camera.

Teasing her husband. Jonah tried to imagine Emma doing the same to him. Jesus, even merely thinking about it made him feel that exquisite mix of conflicted emotion...

Gemma remounted him, this time facing up his body, letting her husband see this strange cock sinking back inside his wife’s red swollen pussy. Once again it was mostly for him to fuck her, to put in the effort, though she was on top. Whether it was because she’d come already, it seemed she got from a standing start up to breathless gasping much quicker than before.

Crying out, “Oh yeah...”

But then she pulled herself up his body, off his cock though still straddling him.

She removed his glasses, signaling what she wanted from him, though perhaps disappointing Emma by taking away her view. Was it dangerous that his minder could not see what was happening? He could hardly do anything about it now.

He slipped his arms under the redhead, helping her move where she needed to be.

“You know what to do,” she said, knees either side of his head, thighs parting over him, swamping him with her wet, red-hot pussy as she sank onto his face.

She held onto the headboard as he ate her, struggling a little at first to find the right position to lap at her, and breathe at the same time. She filled his world, and gave him no choice about it, rocking gently back and forth to graze her sex on his eager mouth, her soaking folds forced down on his lips, her coppery bush tickling his nose.

“Fuck me... tongue... suck...”

He didn't hear all her words, but they weren't really directed at him. All part of the show, her distant husband the real audience.

Jonah didn't mind being used, being the toy for this couple to work out their fantasy. Even as her grinding on his face got a little too intense, her hands sunk in the pillows to support her body as she fucked his face. How could he not enjoy everything about it...

"Oh fuck, yeah..."

As she dismounted, he suspected she'd come again. She kissed him on the mouth, almost gratefully, her hand falling to his hard cock, stroking him.

When it came to the end, and she wanted him to come inside her—firmly instructing him that that was what she wanted—they were as conventional as it came, good old missionary. It allowed him to reach for the bedside table and put his glasses back on, to give his assistant her view once more. Hearing her now sigh through her earpiece as she responded to the visual stimulus added real spark to his performance.

Even so, he was a little tired by then. Gemma did not seem to object to his

slower pace, if anything she practically encouraged it, the way she quietly moaned as he took her in the manner a husband might take a wife.

She was affectionate, her eyes softened somehow, her body compliant, his to take at his preferred pace.

It took a few moments for him to realize this was probably the way to drive her husband crazy across the world, for her to essentially make love to this stranger, act as though he was special to her now, as though she cared for him.

Jonah tried to imagine Emma in this position, how he might view it from afar.

He'd be paranoid that she was going to want to see this guy again, that she might want him more. And though his rational side would know she wasn't going to stop seeing him, his body would feel the fire of jealousy, blending with the thrill of seeing his woman taken by someone else.

“Come inside me... do it... come inside me...” was her only demand, the only remnant of her dominant self by the end.



It was his assumption that since he had met her at the door of the hotel room that this was not to be a spending the night kind of deal. As soon as he was ready, he would be throwing his clothes back on, and heading back into the night leaving her to herself—or in this case, perhaps, leaving her to enjoy time via the Internet with her husband.

But when it was clear they were done, Gemma surprised him by being the one who had to shoot away from there.

She checked the cameras, and packed them into her overnight bag, then also retrieved a small silver laptop from the bathroom.

“You’re welcome to stay,” she said. “The room’s booked, anyway. It’s still early.”

“Thanks,” he said, thinking he might have a horny personal assistant pleased to access this bed as soon as possible. “You’re not sticking around?”

She smiled, taking off her bra and wandering back into the bathroom. “I have a flight to catch, actually.”

“Singapore?” Jonah guessed.

A small nod, and then she was lifting a leg to remove her stocking. “I should be there with him now, but I had some business to attend to here in London.”

Off came the other stocking, and then she turned to step into the large shower booth, which Jonah thought was probably not much smaller than the entire bathroom at his tiny apartment in Oxford.

Jonah watched her turn on the water and keep back from the initial cold stream, before it heated up, and the thought crossed his mind that perhaps she might want some privacy to shower before dashing to the airport.

But she didn't seem bothered that he had followed her into the bathroom.

And then she said, "Want to join me?"

He shook his head, knowing Emma would find him more interesting if he wasn't freshly scrubbed after sex, and Gemma didn't seem disappointed that he preferred to lean against the counter and just watch her.

"So which firm do you work for, Robert? In the City," she asked as she stepped under the water and began running a bar of soap all over her body.

He smiled, and felt his ears burn a little. He just wasn't very good at lying.

"We're not really supposed to talk about all that, are we? On these dates?"

She returned his smile, "I suppose not."

It was tempting to join her in that shower. He felt himself beginning to recover from the last round of passion as he watched her fondling her large breasts, lathering them up with soap, and then run it down over her stomach and between her legs.

The way she was looking at him, though, he felt he needed to offer her more of an answer to her question than a straight refusal.

"Let's just say it's one of the finest establishments on Kitchener Street," he said, hinting at the address of Nate's own company. There was only really one dominant firm on that particular street. Well, what did it matter? There were hundreds, thousands of people at the firm, how could she possibly figure out his profile was a cover knowing that information?

She nodded.

"I like fucking City boys," she said. "I suppose I married one, although he's hardly a trader these days, and he's rarely in the City."

She turned to allow him to watch her washing her behind, and it was clear she enjoyed having him admiring her.

“You like it? Working in the City?”

Jonah inwardly groaned. He’d thought he’d be safe from too much talk about the job on these dates, since the code was not to talk about work if possible. It made him feel he had more homework to do if he was going to continue down this road of dating women who were fond of City gents.

All he could do now was channel memories of Nate, try to recall any vague ramblings about his work that his brother had come out with.

He said: “Well, you know how it is. We’re not in the storage business, we’re in the moving business. Got to keep the trades going, keep the money moving.”

She smiled, nodded. “Busy, busy, busy, huh?”

“Absolutely. But wouldn’t have it any other way. Figure I’ll keep it going five years, maybe ten...”

“And then you’ll retire?” she laughed, and ducked her head under the flow of the water again before reaching for the shampoo.

“Well, I’ll start thinking about maybe having a personal life again,” he said.

As she washed her hair, then rinsed it, he found himself dispelling his concerns about sounding authentic. What did it matter? What did any of it matter? He wouldn’t ever see her again, chances were.

He realized that his hint of anxiety, the slight sense that he had to keep impressing her, was because of that networking of hers. He might have favorited her, but she had asked him out because someone in her network had vouched for him. If he was to keep making progress, and perhaps if he was to secure dates with more women from Nate’s favorites list, he couldn’t afford a woman like Gemma to come away from her date thinking ill of him.

“So that recommendation from your friend in the Network worked out okay?” he asked, and he wasn’t just fishing for compliments.

“Oh very much so,” she said, rinsing off the soap from her body, giving him the kind of show that had seen him return to full hardness watching

her. “And you can be sure if my friends in the network are looking for a good time, I’ll pass on your details.”

“I never heard of networking going on through that website,” he said. “You’re the first person to mention it.”

She shrugged. “I probably talk too much,” she said, turning off the water before exiting the shower stall to grab a white towel. “But you know what? There are

some beautiful women that I talk to through that network.”

She offered him a knowing grin, which silently announced to him that he was about to be richly rewarded with hot married pussy.

“They’re all married too, the ones in your network?”

“Of course,” she said, dropping her towel on the floor. “But trust me, you don’t have to worry about their husbands.”

He nodded, “Well, I guess that’s something you should all have in common.”

Back out in the room he watched her slip on a pair of clean but fairly plain black panties and a matching bra, before stretching that same dress over her curves again, and pulling over her black leather jacket. They talked about nothing much

—he distracted her from trying to pry into his claim of working in the City by telling her how beautiful she was, how incredible it had been to sleep with her, how lucky her husband was. She enjoyed the flattery.

But then with shoes on, as she picked up her bag to leave, she left a final comment that seemed more than just flippant.

“Good luck, Robert. You’ll do well, I know you will.”

“Thank you.”

He escorted her to the door, kissed her one last time before she left, but her final comment stayed with him. Were there underlying nuances in that? That he needed luck, to deal with this network of hers?

Eight

“Room service!”

Okay, so she did startle him a little with that one for a second or two, but then he could tell it was her.

“Very amusing,” he said, feeling so confident it wasn’t room service with an unexpected order that he answered the door in the nude.

Emma flashed her eyes at him as he let her in, her hot little hand closing around his shaft as she strode by him.

“Damn, aren’t you a picture,” she said, looking round the room as though she’d never seen it before—or, he guessed, because she’d seen it before on a television screen, and now wanted to compare things in real life.

“So did you enjoy the show?” he asked, wandering in after her.

“I’ll say,” she said, sauntering up to him, subtly slipping one of her fingers in his mouth, surprising him a little that it was slippery with her juices. Naughty wench. “Next time I get the chance, I’m planning on dominating you like crazy.”

“Mmmm...” he said, tasting her tangy nectar. “Please sir, can I have some more?”

She laughed, but then stepped away, toward the door again. “You’ll have to wait,” she said, pausing sufficiently for confusion to take over his features, before adding: “I have a date tonight, remember? With Clement. Unfinished business.”

Her eyes flashed again, and Jonah felt a jolt of intense heat shoot through his chest. Jesus. She was going out with the guy tonight?

Suddenly, that dark sequined dress of hers seemed very low-cut around her cleavage, very short on her thighs. Had she hiked it up especially to tease him?

She was beaming at his barely concealed awe at how gorgeous she looked, running a hand through her golden hair as she turned to offer him a rear view, her hips swaying gently as though she was dancing for him.

“You like it?”

“Uh... yeah...” he said, with difficulty since his throat had dried up.

Jesus, the dress was short enough so you really could see the curves as her buttocks met her thighs. Her hands came down her body to daintily clutch the hem of her scandalous dress, and show him even more of her behind.

She laughed and playfully slapped her cheeks with both hands. “You want me to find out everything I can from him, don’t you?” she asked. “I might have to be a bad girl to do that...”

Was she testing him? Teasing him to see if he broke, if he suddenly snapped and forbade her to see another man. If he did that, she’d probably decided he wasn’t the man she thought he was. That he was selfish, because he saw other women, and he wasn’t happy with her seeing other guys. That he wasn’t fully open minded. That he was no fun.

“I guess we know he and Martin were using that website,” he said, trying to project calm, even nonchalance at the prospect of losing her, albeit temporarily, to another man.

“Uh-huh,” she said, perhaps a touch disappointed that he was resisting her teasing.

“So we need you to try to find out anything you can about their trading activity.

You know, whether there was anything strange going on—erratic. Big trades, unusual successes.”

“Right,” she said now looking at the large mirror on the wall behind the television, “Because of what Graham told you?”

She began fondling her breasts in the mirror, as though they were cushions that needed to be fluffed out to impress her date to their maximum potential.

“And because Nate’s boss died, and he signed off on Nate’s deals.”

She giggled. “I feel really worked up after watching you and Gemma.” God, he could see her nipples straining against that dress. “You think he’ll want to play around a little, this time?”

Sitting on the bed now, there was nothing to conceal his massively hard erection.

“You don’t want a little something before you go?” he asked her, seeing her eyes in the mirror moving to take in his response to her show.

It provoked one of her million-candle smiles.

“Oh I want to,” she said, slowly, seductively, “but I really shouldn’t. I’m all dressed up, ready to go.”

It felt dangerous, letting her go while she was all worked up like this. But he told himself, he did want to experience this, did want to experience sharing her. Look how hard he was, as proof.

“Hey, can I show you something?” she asked.

“Uh... sure.”

She turned to the bed, lifted one knee onto it, and brushed her hair back over her shoulders with a hand before dropping down onto all fours on the bed by him, swamping him with her fragrance, which wasn’t her usual coconut, incidentally.

She’d put something else on—sweet, but a little more floral, a little more sophisticated—while she’d been watching him with Gemma.

Her dress seemed to ride up her thighs by itself as she presented her behind for his enjoyment. She was really driving him wild only to be leaving him high and dry. The black thong she wore hid almost nothing, and as she slid her knees further apart, it suddenly dawned on him what she was showing off.

She tilted up her butt, and then one hand delicately slipped aside her panties to confirm everything. There was her beautiful pink flower, all slick with her juices already, exquisite and completely hairless.

She’d shaved—and she’d done it for her date with another man.

“You think he’ll like it?” she asked.

“Jesus,” was all he could say.



It was a waste of a five-star hotel room, but he could not stay the night there, not after what he’d seen, not after knowing what was about to happen.

He’d had to watch Emma reapplying her make-up in the en suite after her little show on the bed. And she didn’t just do the normal make-up job, it seemed to him: she really vamped it up. Heavy on the eyeliner, heavy on the lipstick, heavy on her brand new perfume.

He’d offered to warm her up with a little time between her thighs, but she clearly liked the idea of keeping him waiting, keeping him frustrated, keeping him all wound up and ready to go as soon as she came back to him after the date.

“I have to be fresh for him,” she’d said with a sassy shrug, somehow knowing which buttons to press to stir up those butterflies in his stomach, and the raging hard-on between his legs.

Well, he wasn’t getting any sleep in that luxurious hotel bed after that, after seeing her check herself one last time in the mirror, hiking the hem of her dress a little from where it had been, although perhaps that had been just for Jonah’s benefit, torturing him one last time before leaving him for another man.

So many emotions flowing through him, he couldn’t even sit still. He was thrilled that she was about to have a fun night, and some hot, steamy sex with a new guy. He even enjoyed the bittersweet sensation of jealousy, knowing that she was going to be his again soon after. He enjoyed the feeling his body was putting him through, in gearing itself up to win her back at the earliest possible opportunity.

He enjoyed knowing she was a bad girl, a sexy little imp out there to take full advantage of her rampant sexuality.

But then there was the fear. No matter how many times he told himself she would be right back with him soon as she was done with Clement, it didn't quell the nerves. He had Kaia's words in his head—though he felt such a strong tie to Emma, she was just having fun, she wasn't really his to feel possessive about.

Clement could show her a good time, and perhaps she would be bored of Jonah and his bizarre murder investigation. He'd show her that there was more to life than repeat encounters with a lowly academic like Jonah Fielding.

She was too good for him, he'd always thought that. The first time he'd dated her, it was by tricking her that he was something he wasn't, a wealthy City trader. Perhaps part of his arousal regarding her going out and seeing other men was from his guilt that she was that much more attractive than him, and younger, and just more fun. He didn't want to limit her experiences. If she was allowed to see other guys, she might spend longer in this relationship with Jonah before getting bored.

He tried to shake the heavy mix of feelings and semi-paranoid thinking out of his head. He had to get out of that hotel room, head back to Nate's apartment and get back to the packing, even this late at night. He needed something to distract him.



It didn't take long to get back to West India Quay from the hotel, a short ride on the Tube before changing for the Docklands Light Railway, the monorail that trotted along over the rooftops of Shadwell and Limehouse and out to London Docklands. Half an hour later he was stepping off at West India Quay station, descending the stairs to ground level to walk the few hundred yards into Nate's building.

All the way, he clutched his mobile phone as though he was a devoted Catholic with his prayer beads.

He felt almost numb as the elevator stopped on the 22 nd floor, and he approached the apartment front door. He was happy that somewhere out there she was enjoying herself—he had to hang onto that feeling to

maintain his sanity. But it also provoked that little little tickle of wickedness inside him, which kept pushing his erection up to full hardness each time it returned, when he thought about how she looked in that dress, how excited she was to be going on that date, how wet she would be preparing to have sex with the first new guy she'd been with since meeting Jonah. How extra hot she'd be knowing that Jonah was back here waiting for her, on edge about her being with someone else.

The packing did not go particularly well, his attention tending to drift. He just couldn't stop wondering what was going on.

He sent her a text an hour into the date, another text two hours into the date.

Brief, not too disruptive he thought, simply stating: how's it going? And then, hope you're having fun!

It was frustrating not to receive anything in reply from her. But she was probably so caught up in it all, she didn't have the chance. Had he texted Emma during his dates with all those women? Not so much.

Three hours into the date, she sent a brief text saying:

>Hey! Dinner was fun. Having some drinks at a bar nearby. Lots of drinks.

Might go on to a club soon... :-)

That left him somewhat breathless. She really was having fun—and now the thought of her dancing with this guy at a club made Jonah's heart quicken. He

remembered how she'd been on her first date with him.

He felt so nervous he was shaking as he composed a reply. He deleted his first draft before sending it—he didn't want to convey any kind of anxiety for her, he wanted her to feel supported, appreciated.

>Hope you're having lots of fun, he's probably desperate to get you back to his place by now, you look incredible :-P

Then there was nothing for another couple of hours, and Jonah found himself going crazy with the emotions. There was some mad kind of joy at the thought that she must have gone home with him by now, that she was finally going through with it, that it was the only reason she couldn't text him just yet. And at the same time irritation that she wasn't updating him on exactly what she was doing, and that he couldn't see her in the way she had seen him with Gemma.

He found himself imagining her being impaled by the world's biggest cock, his paranoia driving him to the conclusion that after Clement, she would come back to him and want nothing less than porn-style enormity inside her.

He shot over a quick text message checking everything was okay—a perfectly reasonable message, he thought, considering that she was a lone female out on the town with a relative stranger.

>Having a wonderful time... he's a real party animal... heading back to his place ;-)

God, he nearly blew a gasket.



Waiting, there was a lot of waiting. It was strangely pleasurable, but at the same time agonizing.

All those questions whirling around his head about what Emma was doing, and how he really felt about it.

All those feelings running into each other—fear, excitement, jealousy, arousal, frustration, hope. The debate running through his mind: did he want her to actually go all the way with Clement, or not? He never seemed to feel the same way about it from one moment to the next.

Time seemed to grind along so very slowly, and yet when he did look at a clock, it often surprised him how much time had actually passed without him really noticing.

Through it all, it seemed, he was hard or at least semi-hard at the growing certainty that his Emma had strayed properly this time. And as he waited, along with that constant sense of arousal, came the growing pain inside him that was the realization that he did, truly, love her when all was said and done—and the fear that if she found out he felt that way, she would run for the hills.

And then the buzzer sounded—loud, harsh in the silence. Jonah had been lying in bed by that point, in a pair of boxer shorts, and he'd totally lost track of time.

He hadn't exactly been asleep, neither had he been fully awake—it was like some kind of limbo.

God, it was nearly morning. The darkness of night was being clearly diluted by a sun that was at least close to breaching the horizon again.

Emma had not sent word for hours. He knew only that she had been planning to go home with Clement, but the rest of the night had been a complete mystery.

She had stayed overnight with him.

The second burst from the buzzer filled him with hope—that she was back for him, that he might reclaim her, and confirm his status with her. As he moved to pick up the intercom, it occurred to him that Emma shouldn't need to be buzzed up to the apartment, she knew the code for the door.

“Yes?” he answered tentatively.

“Mr Fielding, sir? Sorry it's so early. Mrs Lily Foster to see you. Seems kind of insistent.”

Jonah felt his heart sink into his stomach.

“Okay, thanks Jeremy. Let her up.”

He put his bathrobe on, not expecting Lily to stay long. It was curious she felt the need to come to Nate's flat, but whatever she wanted, Jonah didn't want her sticking around. Not when she made Emma feel so uncomfortable.

“I don’t like her,” she had said. “I don’t want you seeing her.”

And here she was, coming straight out of the elevator in a big coat over a cream alpaca sweater and jeans, sturdy yet feminine black boots, large sunglasses obscuring her face like a movie star, heading straight through into the apartment, where he was holding the door open for her.

“Have you seen the papers?” she asked him.

“Today’s? Hardly. It’s 5am.”

He hadn’t slept, he was a little frustrated that Emma hadn’t updated him on what was going on, a little worried what might happen if she arrived now and Lily was here. The irritation leaked into his tone of voice.

“Well it’s all over the Internet already, of course.”

Lily stood among the white couches of the living room area of the apartment, and as the front door clicked shut behind him, she reached into an inner pocket of her coat and retrieved a newspaper, hurling it onto the coffee table.

The Guardian.

The headline read: Left Behind by the Black Widow: Victim’s Widow Dulls Pain with Nights of Debauchery

His heart jumping all over the place in horror, Jonah picked up the paper. It bore

a large picture of Lily Foster herself, no less, and quite an attractive looking picture at that. The byline on the article was no less shocking because it was so predictable: Harold Keeley.

“You said I could trust him,” Lily said, removing her sunglasses, her face ashen.

“You said he was on our side.”

Jonah sighed. “I thought he was.”

“If any members of the press weren’t camped outside my house before, they are now,” she said. “They even chased us when I took Aaron in a taxi over to his grandmother’s.”

“I’m sorry.”

Scanning the story, he felt hollow inside, his organs burned away by guilt and shame. He had done this, he had exposed Lily and her little boy to this. Keeley had written a detailed expose on her, and how she was using an online dating site to “order a different man each night with the convenience of a pizza delivery”.

Below the fold, there was a cluster of semi-blurred images showing three guys entering her house on separate occasions, all pictured late at night.

None of the men featured in the copy were Jonah, which made him feel a hint of relief. But then, there weren’t any names for the men involved, they were just bit parts in the overall play about Lily’s reckless rebound from tragedy into self-destructive promiscuity.

If this was all true, Lily had been nearly as busy as he had in the bedroom. He could hardly blame her. At least some part of his recent activity could be seen as distracting himself from the pain of losing his brother. This could almost be the story of his own recent past, with some of the names and locations changed.

And if you looked beyond the sensationalism, Keeley had actually written a piece that was quite sympathetic to Lily and her plight. It wasn’t so much pronouncing the evils of a woman going wild after being widowed, as the fact that after such a torturous end to her marriage, Lily was a broken woman who had descended to taking whatever pleasures of the flesh she perceived were still open to her.

But the thing was, if you were just skim-reading, as most readers would, the piece set her up as a tramp who thought so little of herself following her husband’s death that she would sleep with anything that moved.

“I told him everything,” Lily said, removing her coat. “I felt safe doing it, too.

And the bottom line was you were there to back him up.”

“I wouldn’t have told you that if I didn’t believe it to be true.”

He tried not to direct any anger Lily’s way—she was right, of course. He bore the responsibility for this.

In a moment or two his mobile phone was out, and he was pulling the business card from its place pinned to the stainless steel fridge by a magnet, and dialing Keeley’s number.

The guy answered on the second or third ring—had to know that he was going to call sooner or later.

“Jonah, what a pleasant—”

“What the hell did were you thinking writing an article like that about Lily Foster?” he barked down the phone.

“I had no choice—”

“No choice but to throw her under a bus?” Jonah felt the adrenaline flowing, and not in a good way. He hated to feel angry at anyone, hated to get in any kind of a fight. He said: “I thought you were playing the long game, Mr Keeley. That’s what you said, wasn’t it?”

“Look, you have to—”

“I mean, this stuff wasn’t even to do with the bloody case! You just trashed someone’s good name for no reason at all.”

“I had to write—”

“I hope you got a good fee for that piece, Mr Keeley, because I’m going to tell anyone I can who is involved in this case to steer well clear of you in future.”

“They were going to write about you, Jonah. They were going to write about you and Lily, and then they were going to keep digging, and write about you and Emma, and then they were going to keep on keeping on until all the details of your sex life were out there in black and white.”

“What—?” Jonah felt the burning ice stabbing through his heart.

“Trust me. That guy you watched sleep with her, with Lily Foster? He was trying to sell his story.”

“Jason? He was trying to what?”

“He was making the rounds in Fleet Street, seeing which paper would offer the most. He recognized you, you see? Or at least, he recognized her. Then he did some digging and figured out who you were.”

“And what, he found someone willing to pay for the story?” Jonah was livid, but somehow the shock of being betrayed like that just made him feel cold, numb.

He looked across at Lily, and she looked pale—and no longer angry at him. If it was Jason’s fault—

Keeley said, “Plenty of offers, as it turned out. My paper had to match them, and it took a heck of a lot of persuading, too.”

“But you didn’t write about me,” Jonah said.

“I wish I could have avoided writing about her, too. But it was out there, that this Jason guy had slept with Lily Foster. The stuff about you being there, watching them—well, he was holding that back until someone actually handed him a check.”

“And you paid him?”

“My paper did. So I was kind of obligated to put together some kind of piece.

But at least we had Jason Bennett under an exclusive contract. He couldn’t take it to anyone else after that.”

“I don’t understand—you completely trashed her—”

“Had to put enough out there about Lily Foster to stop the other papers looking for more themselves.”

“— Totally wrecked her reputation.”

“Don’t you see, Jonah?” Keeley stressed. “If your face gets in all the papers in a big way, your investigation comes to a complete stop. If you go out on a date with the Black Widow, she’ll recognize you immediately.”

“I suppose—”

“Whoever she is, there is zero chance she’d miss the coverage about you. And as for anyone else connected to the Black Widow—they’re not going to deal with you either if they imagine it might end up being leaked to the newspapers...”

“But you had to go into quite so much detail about her?” Jonah felt his case against Harold Keeley evaporating.

He looked round, and Lily was no longer there. She wasn’t in the kitchen either.

Probably in the bathroom.

“Lily’s the sexy widow left behind by a mysterious serial killer. She was always going to be paraded about in the tabloids, it was just a matter of time. From what she told me, even if you hadn’t given her the confidence, at some point she probably would have started dating again—and she was never the type to keep things to a single, monogamous relationship.”

Jonah perched on the couch. He felt more than a little foolish, but the guy was right. Lily Foster might have been an ordinary housewife and mother turned widow, but she had a beauty and a poise that somehow transcended her station in life. She was more than just attractive—the way she moved, the way she dressed, the way she carried herself: she had an almost unnatural air of glamour and feminine style about her. Any newspaper wanting to delve into the lives of anyone affected by the Black Widow—and they all wanted to just now, it seemed—was going to fall for her.

“Doing it this way, we’re controlling the public image of her to some extent,” the reporter continued. “Believe me, the rest of the press sees her as some kind of sexy Jackie O type figure by now, with a little Sharon Stone bad girl mixed in.”

“Okay, look,” he sighed, ran a hand through his hair, “I can see why you did it, and I appreciate you leaving me out of it... but I feel like you should have at least told us about this before you ran it.”

“I had very little time to engineer all this. That guy Jason was peddling his wares round town, anyone could have snapped him up at any point. Look, the heat will die down after a few days. Lily’s story’s all out there—there’s nothing illegal in it. Mrs Hubbard from Church Street, Middle-on-the-Wold might tut-tut a few times while she’s supping her tea over it, but no one important is really going to hold anything against her.”

“A few days. I hope it’s a few days.”

“By then, the press will be buying on a bigger story.”

“A bigger story?”

Keeley said: “Can’t talk about that over the phone. You learn nothing from the whole phone-hacking thing last year? We’ll talk, Jonah. Soon.”

The guy hung up the phone leaving Jonah feeling like an idiot. He’d lost any hint of control over that conversation. Ended up basically agreeing with Keeley that his strategy had probably been the best option open to them all.

He felt all flushed by humiliation. How could he explain Keeley’s approach without it all seeming to come across as blunt self-interest from Jonah’s perspective?

He hauled himself to his feet, tired, dejected. She deserved some sort of explanation.

“So it was Jason, then?”

He heard her voice from the bedroom, assumed she was just coming out from using the bathroom. She seemed calm, none of her earlier anger or resentment remaining. Just that smooth, sophisticated, oh-so-sexy voice of hers, as it had been before.

“He was offering his story around town,” Jonah said, wandering toward her.

“And let me guess, Keeley sacrificed me to keep you and your investigation out of the papers?”

“Seems that way.”

He stepped around the wardrobe that provided part of the pseudo-wall defining the bedroom portion of the open-plan apartment, and there she was, lying on the bed up against the pillows, arms outstretched to offer herself up to him completely, her coat gone, her jeans gone—everything gone, in fact, other than a sexy set of white lingerie complete with garter belt and stockings.

It wasn't the kind of ensemble a woman would wear just for the hell of it.

“I forgive you,” she purred. “Now come show me how sorry you are.”

He stood there, stunned, and after an entire night of waiting on tenterhooks for a girlfriend who had gone home with another man, he was hard as a rock.

And it was just then that he heard the high-pitched beeps of codes being tapped into the electronic lock of the front door.

Emma had returned.



She was all smiles to begin with, as Jonah wandered over to greet her, horrified at the situation he now found himself in.

“God I missed you!” she said as she leapt into his arms.

She smelled of alcohol and cigarettes and perfume—that strange new one that he still found unfamiliar on her.

“I’m sorry I kind of... lost touch...” she said with a mischievous smirk. Her voice was a little slurred, as though she was still a little tipsy. “We got so unbelievably trashed...”

“Oh, it’s okay,” he said, his voice flat, dazed.

“You coped okay?”

She pressed herself against him and felt his hardness, which prompted an enormous smile across her pretty face. “So you want to hear about my night?”

He felt a little sick, and it was nothing to do with her evening spent with another man. In fact, he was starting to feel anger at Lily for spoiling his enjoyment of Emma’s first date with someone else.

“Of course,” he said. “There’s... just... there’s something I need to tell you...”

He wanted to pick her up and devour her, to ravish her, to consume her wickedness. But he knew what was waiting in his bed, and that she would not be too pleased about it.

“Okay, can it wait ‘till I’ve got these clothes off?” she pulled off her jacket, dumped over the back of the nearest couch. “And that bathrobe of yours...”

He wanted to hold her, pull her back out of the front door, away from the apartment. To concoct some mad story about a burst pipe or a gas leak. But he couldn’t.

She broke away from him and strode purposefully towards the bedroom, her heels knocking against the wooden floor.

“Hello,” he heard Lily’s voice, “you must be Emma.”

A gasp, and then she turned on her heels, storming past him, grabbing her coat on her way out.

Hissing, “I thought more of you than that.”

And what could he say? He was standing there with nothing much more than a bathrobe and a hard-on, with a seductive brunette sprawled across his bed in a set of femme fatale underwear.



He was just standing there, feeling as though his whole world had just caved in.

He really, really hadn't intended to get involved in any kind of a relationship.

From the beginning, he had seen himself as some kind of disposable asset in the hunt for his brother's killer—putting everything he had into finding the evil woman who had ended Nate's existence, not even worrying if it cost him his life as long as he found her and somehow informed the authorities.

Now all that seemed secondary.

He wanted Emma.

How long was he standing there, his brain frozen in horror, unable to make any kind of concrete decision as to how he was supposed to manage this?

"I'm sorry, I read her completely wrong," Lily said, snapping him out of his stupor.

She wandered past him now, wearing her jeans and that cream sweater again, putting on her coat as she approached him.

"I thought you two were just friends-with-benefits."

"Huh?" he said, in touch with his inner bewildered caveman.

She patted him on the shoulder. "She's in love with you, dear Jonah."

"In love with me?"

"She might like the idea of you fooling around with other women, from what I've heard. But if there's any hint of you getting too close to someone else...

well, I've seen it in men, put it that way. Even Julian got a little upset at some of the guys I was with."

"What do I do now?"

Hovering at the front door, she shrugged. “You might be best letting things cool down a little. She might not believe you whatever you say just now.”

“But if I let things cool down a little, she might think I don’t want her. She might... move on.”

“It’s possible. But not if she really does love you. And I think that is unmistakable.”

Lily opened the door, and Jonah said: “Wait—what are you going to do? About the press, I mean, barricading your house.”

She said: “I’ll find some innocuous hotel somewhere, lay low. I’ll be okay.”

“Let me know if there’s anything I can do,” he said, feeling somewhat useless.

Lily smiled, “You’ll get her back, Jonah. She’s beautiful, by the way. You’ve done extremely well for yourself there.”

He nodded, and the door clicked shut behind her, her parting words ringing in his ears. He had done extremely well for himself with Emma—too well. And now, she would probably realize she was too good for the likes of him.



The pain of losing Emma was far beyond anything he felt at the thought of her being with someone else. Jonah’s insides had been crushed, and now he felt a continual throbbing combined with real nausea that threatened to bring up anything he ate, if indeed, he could summon up any kind of an appetite.

All day he had this awful sense of free fall, as though he had jumped off the pinnacle of a skyscraper and was rushing headlong toward the ground. He knew the ground was approaching rapidly, he knew he had to stop this dreadful descent, but there was absolutely nothing he could do about it.

He wandered about the apartment indiscriminately throwing things into cardboard boxes.

His lunch—a normally reliable sandwich from the nearby Pret—ended up in the trash after only one bite. After that, he didn't want to go back to the apartment.

He wanted to get away from the whole place.

The DLR took him into the City, and he made his way over to Tottenham Court Road, where he could slump himself down in front of a computer at his familiar Internet cafe.

There were Internet cafes closer to home, but he'd always come back to this one for its sheer size and the anonymity it afforded him when making use of a site like No Strings. Now, though, the place offered memories of being with Emma.

He loaded up the website, and to his surprise found another message waiting for him from one of the women he'd recently favorited.

One of the women from Nate's list.

She went by the name of Victoria, whether it was her real name or not. Married, blonde, no clue about her age but she was attractive in a very refined way, it seemed.

Her husband would be watching. Jonah would be expected to be very discreet, of course, and open-minded.

He came recommended, so she trusted he had the stamina and the skill she was

looking for.

And if he wanted her, he had to go that very evening.

Jonah felt a fresh wave of pain inside that Emma might not be there, that he might have to go it alone. He'd have to spend the rest of the day looking for her, calling her, texting her, emailing her, trying to get her to come back to him. But he couldn't pass up this opportunity.

He accepted Victoria's invitation.

Nine

He knocked on the door and waited for a moment or two.

The man who opened it appeared to be some kind of butler or valet, dressed in a smart black suit, white shirt and tie.

"Do come in," he said, stepping back to admit Jonah into the suite.

Jonah glanced at the surroundings—a lavish room of substantial proportions, great swathes of darkness obscured the true size of the room. The furniture was fairly minimal, looking to him as though it had been purposefully cleared.

And in the middle of the great expanse stood a blonde woman in a little black dress, waiting.

Jonah felt himself tingle. This, presumably, was the woman he was to be with.

She was a few inches shorter than he was, with long ash blonde hair that cascaded mostly down one side of her head over her shoulder and down to the peak of her breasts.

The dress was skin-tight, and very low cut. It emphasized her willowy figure.

He would have said she was about his age, possibly a year or two older. Pretty in a refined, elegant fashion, though to Jonah much of the allure stemmed from the nervous energy emanating from her eyes. Her tanned skin and the glittering diamond jewelry around her neck, one of her wrists and her fingers indicated to Jonah that she was a wealthy wife, although something in the proudness of her carriage spoke to him of an intellect not found in your average trophy wife.

There was a man in the room as well, sitting on one of the few remaining pieces of furniture, though the darkness had been positioned to hide his face. He wore an expensive suit, a gold watch and patent leather shoes. He was slightly portly around the belly, and though Jonah couldn't see his

face, the impression he had was that the other man was much older than the woman Jonah assumed was his

wife. Perhaps 55 to her 35.

But Jonah didn't check the man out too closely, doing his best to look away at all times. He couldn't really see anyone else, but somehow from the size of the room and the knowledge that the butler guy had to be around somewhere, he got the sense that there might well be others watching, too.

The woman, Victoria, gazed at him, assessing him, and as Jonah approached, her eyes sparked to reveal a hint of lust and perhaps some kind of sense that they were both in this together. They were the show, for however many men there were out there watching.

"Robert," she smiled, and shook her hair out, a trifle coquettishly.

"Hello," he replied. "Victoria, is it?"

"If you like."

She stepped closer to him. Well, what did it matter what she was called? The instructions he received were to take her as he pleased, to own her from the beginning, do as he wanted with her.

He stepped up, and gently ran a couple of fingers down her body, checking out her curves, and that dress, which appeared to be made of velvet.

She didn't object, and, in fact, puffed out her chest in some unconscious attempt to impress him.

He pushed up the hem of her dress to reveal the tops of her stockings.

It felt strange to be the focus of the room's audience, no matter how large it was.

But as he edged in to kiss her cheek, and then, as she encouraged him, her lips, Jonah felt the stirrings of attraction dulling his awareness of anything around them.

Her lips were as sweet as her scent, which might have been a little too saccharine except that she wore only a hint of perfume—as though it was so expensive, it couldn't simply be sprayed everywhere at will. She shook her hair out of her face and tasted his tongue, their kiss turning explicit even this early on.

Her husband, if that was who the man was, would have wanted her to be explicit.

As they kissed, she ran her hands over his chest, checking out what he offered her, before her hands started fumbling at his shirt buttons.

Jonah slipped her dress up even further, revealing the suspenders holding up her stockings, luxurious black lace panties, and then her garter belt. She'd taken care to dress up for her new lover.

The man watched, sitting there completely motionless.

Deciding he needed to see more of her, Jonah slipped the straps of her dress over her tanned shoulders, slipping his hands inside the skin-hugging material to roughly push the garment down over her curves, revealing her matching black lace bra, her flat stomach, and more of that tanned skin of hers, which offered absolutely no tan lines.

He dropped to his knees before her to continue his hands' journey over her hips, and down her legs, letting the material pool on the floor around her.

Her panties were semi-transparent, he could see more of her wonderfully smooth skin, could tell there was no hair between her legs. He was allowed to take from her what he wanted, wasn't he? He leaned in, touched his nose to the front panel of her panties, breathing in the subtle sweetness of her perfume laced with the unmistakable spice of female arousal.

He kissed her bare flesh by the edge of her panties, and slid his hand slowly up her inner thigh, over the nylon of her stocking, the black band around its top, and the smooth hot flesh above it.

Then he was touching it gently to her sex, feeling the heat through the thin material of her underwear, feeling the dampness seeping through as he nudged in against her pussy lips.

She'd been aroused before he'd arrived, excited by the mere prospect of doing this in front of her husband, or whoever was watching.

He felt her breathing step up a gear as he stood while continuing to touch her, and then she was once again unfastening the buttons of his shirt, pulling him to her, kissing his mouth as she pulled open his shirt to view his bare chest.

Shaking her hair seductively.

Victoria smiled enigmatically, and then she sank slowly to her knees in front of him, her hands finding his belt.

Was Jonah supposed to be taking more control of her? The instructions were to take what he wanted from her—not necessarily to dominate her.

She slipped open his fly and parted his pants, pushing them down with his boxers to reveal the full hardness of his cock.

“Mmm...” she said, loud enough for her audience to hear as her fingers curled around his shaft. “Such a beautiful cock.”

Without hesitation she opened her mouth around Jonah's tip, and sank down on him, the heat intense as she began to suck on him, her hand gripping him, pumping him, revealing the wedding ring that confirmed her probable link with the man in the chair.

She took him deep, but periodically withdrew to lick him, even just to look at him, to take in the newness of his cock, that her husband was allowing her to enjoy.

Then suddenly another man was there next to Jonah. Not the man in the chair.

He was the same age as Jonah or slightly younger, short dark hair, wearing a gray suit that was well tailored.

Jonah was surprised—shocked, even—but felt it important to hide his reaction.

The other man simply offered him a nod, as though to inform him that they were of like minds, of like status.

Without preamble, the man opened his fly, withdrew his own hard cock for Victoria to take in her other hand. She stroked them both before stretching her lips around the other man's tip, showing him what she'd just shown Jonah.

She alternated between them, indulging in this excess of cock for quite a while, underlying her status as a naughty wife for the man in the chair and whoever else might be watching.

Jonah kept his eyes on her face, aroused as much by how obviously she was

enjoying herself as by her pumping him, and periodically taking him into her hot mouth. He wondered if this was the kind of pleasure a husband might have from watching his wife in such a way. How Julian might have felt watching Lily with other men.

How might it be to watch someone like Emma in such a position.

The way the man sat there in his chair, it made Victoria seem objectified to some extent—she was putting on a show, appreciated for her wanton ways with these two men, acting the part of a whore or a stripper, and it seemed to be at the direction of her husband although he remained silent.

Jonah had to think she was not merely doing this for her husband's benefit, though. The way she relished playing with the two hard cocks, lashing them with her tongue, stroking them all over her face, moaning and closing her eyes as she took each one inside her mouth—she was happy with this deal.

Maybe she'd even instigated it.

When she stood, Jonah sank to his knees, reaching to pull her panties down while she pressed her mouth to the other man's, his big cock firmly in her hands.

He had no need to unfasten her suspenders to draw her underwear down, over her thighs and her stockings. She'd been prepared for this.

Her shaven pussy had also been prepared, it seemed, and now stood ready, seeping her moisture. Jonah leaned in to breathe her scent, and touch his tongue gently to her sex to sample her wetness.

Before he could delve further into her sweetness, Victoria pulled away and sank to her knees in front of the other man, taking his cock into her mouth again, but pushing up her behind for Jonah.

She tasted faintly citrusy, as though she had cleaned herself with something sweet and sharp. He'd never experienced anything quite like it. Jonah wanted more, ending up lying on his back, staring up at her, guiding her down onto his mouth.

He couldn't tell if this was the kind of thing the man, or the rest of the hidden audience wanted to see. The woman, Victoria, seemed to enjoy him sucking on her, penetrating her with his tongue, her hips moving gently to encourage him, or

perhaps make best use of his tongue, the rough lace of her stocking tops brushing against his ears as she moved.

After a while, he couldn't tell how long, Victoria moved slowly down his body, her soft warm skin brushing his face as she went, pausing slightly to allow her soft breasts to trail over him, so he could briefly suck on her hard nipples.

Then she was straddling his hips, his hardness pressed against her burning sex.

She kissed him as her blonde locks fell around their faces like some kind of privacy curtain. She had a devilish smile on her face, which seemed reassuring to Jonah, allaying his concerns that she might be under some kind of coercion to do this.

Her tongue delved inside his lips, tasting herself on him. She moaned quietly.

He felt her hands fumble between her legs, grabbing his cock, positioning him so that his tip nudged into the hot wetness of her pussy.

Another, longer pause made Jonah think she was waiting for some kind of signal of approval from her husband. This was a big moment for a man watching his wife with another man, after all. He might want to savor it.

She had a certain sparkle in her eyes as she sank slowly onto him, taking his full length inside her, which made Jonah think it was because she was

married, because she was misbehaving.

He couldn't tell what the other guy was doing. With a beautiful blonde wife riding him, he didn't really care. Perhaps the guy had taken a seat again, to watch rather than participate.

Then Jonah felt movement down by his legs, and though he couldn't really see in the dim lighting, he got the impression the other man was behind Victoria, kneeling over them both. He felt fingers skimming his cock close to where it sank inside Victoria, not really purposefully touching him, just accidental contact as the guy lined up.

It took Jonah a few moments to realize what was going on. And then Victoria's eyes widened with what Jonah took to be pleasant surprise. Then her face registered strain, and she began to moan.

Jonah felt movement against his cock while he was inside the blonde. It was the strangest experience.

Another man was inside her at the same time as Jonah, though penetrating her anally. God, was this real?

Jonah lay there, allowing Victoria to move as she wanted on his cock, instead of trying to force anything himself. He had no experience of this before, no idea whether any movement on his own part might hurt her.

She didn't seem to object to his remaining still. Jonah could feel the motion through her pussy wall as the other man slowly thrust inside her rear.

The woman was breathing hard, her groans plaintive, the strain in her flushed face telling in the little lines between her eyebrows. But Jonah didn't think she was in pain, it was pleasurable to her.

"Oh...."

He felt her hand slide between her body and his, down between her legs, where she could touch her clit while this extraordinary thing was happening to her, this double penetration. She was getting off on this, then.

"Oh my God..."

Jonah turned his head momentarily, snatching a glance at the man watching them

—though only a glance. He'd hidden it well, but in that brief glimpse, he still couldn't see the man's face. He could see only the smart shoes, the expensive suit, the apparently relaxed stance as he sat back in the armchair, legs parted, his hand in his lap gently stroking himself through his pants.

The woman was wailing now, looking up over her shoulder at the man fucking her ass.

“Oh yes.... Yes....”

She looked down at Jonah and whispered: “Fuck me... do it...”

Jonah felt a little shocked at all this, but began to stir inside her himself. She was very wet, but tight. The feeling of the other man pressing against her pussy from

the other side, fucking her while Jonah did from his side, was bizarre.

Then the other man withdrew, to leave Victoria riding Jonah, her cries steadily increasing in pitch and volume.

“Wait... wait...” she groaned, looking at him.

Then she was shuddering over him, shaking as her climax overwhelmed her, yelling at him: “Come in me, come in me...”

Jonah let go, releasing his hot seed deep inside her, and looking up to see the other man standing above them both, jacking himself until he was spraying his cream all over the blonde's back.

“Oh yeah.... oh God yeah...”

Jesus.

Jonah just lay there for a moment or two, shocked though trying not to seem that way. The blonde woman, Victoria, picked herself up, giving him a little smile though it appeared she was trying to look solemn for this occasion. She turned, and walked over to the seated man, shaking her

blonde mane over one shoulder, before coming to a standstill in front of him.

The man, whether he was her husband or not, seemed impressed with her. He pulled himself up to his feet, stood in front of her, ran a tanned hand down her arms, over her hips as though assessing a race horse.

Jonah jumped as something landed on him—his clothes. He looked up to see the other guy having dumped them on his stomach. He was holding his own clothes, and now flicked his head at Jonah to indicate they had to get out of there, his eyes emphasizing the point.

Before he followed the other man out, he caught a glimpse of the blonde woman, naked other than her stockings and suspenders, leading her well-to-do husband out of the room by another door. Perhaps to reclaim her, to indulge in her wickedness.

Just as Jonah had wanted to do with Emma after her date with Clement.



The valet came back to show him and the other guy out to another room in this enormous hotel suite, if that was what it really was, so that he could get changed, back into his clothes.

They dressed in an awkward silence, though when Jonah looked across at the other man, he didn't seem to be unnerved by any of it.

Jonah felt totally unsettled. They had just fucked the same woman—at the same time. His cock had been mere millimeters away from the other man's, effectively rubbing up against it, certainly occasionally accidentally brushing against it, though with Victoria's devilish body keeping them apart inside her.

Actually, when all was said and done, he had been surprisingly okay with it. It was just that it had been a rather extreme experience for a sheltered academic like him.

And now that the two of them were alone, there was a distinct chill in the air between them.

“That guy was her husband, right?” he said, trying to break the awkward silence.

The other man shrugged. “Sure. Whatever.”

Jonah nodded. They hadn’t been told not to talk amongst themselves. There weren’t exactly any rules on the No Strings website for this sort of situation.

They had only that odd sense of mild homophobia that often exists in male changing rooms: don’t look at the other guy, in case he thinks you’re attempting to proposition him.

“You’re in the City, too?”

“Of course,” the other man said.

“Haven’t seen you around, is all,” Jonah tried to explain his sudden curiosity. He got the impression that this guy had done all this before, perhaps many times.

And that normally, you didn’t talk to each other afterwards.

Pulling up his pants, the other man said: “I’ve been on secondment on Wall

Street for six months.”

As though that was some kind of explanation for why Jonah hadn’t seen him before.

“My name’s Robert,” he said.

“Liam.”

He nodded, and was surprised that the man, fully dressed by now, actually took two paces over, and held out a hand for him to shake. “I’ll probably see you around,” he said, with an almost imperceptible—but still nevertheless undoubtedly there—hint of warmth. They had, after all, been fairly extensively introduced.

Brothers in double penetration.

“Absolutely,” said Jonah, wanting to ask him more, though feeling not only that more questions right now would be inappropriate, but also the strange sense that he might get an opportunity to do so at another time.

Dressed, Liam led them both quietly out of the room, closing the large, heavy white paneled door behind them. The valet was waiting for them out in the hallway, holding up a silver plate on which two plain manila envelopes were sitting.

Jonah watched the other man take one of the envelopes, prompting him to pick up the second.

Liam did not stop to open the envelope, merely gave the valet a curt nod, and headed left for the door of the suite. Jonah could only do likewise, trying to keep his confusion and slight sense of dread to himself.

The two of them rode the elevator to the lobby, and once again silence pervaded.

Then, as they stepped out on ground level, Liam touched the one corner of his envelope to his temple in mock salute, and said to him: “Anon, then.”

Jonah gave him an understated nod in return, trying to play it cool, and let the other man walk ahead, to the exit where he slipped away into the night.

He waited until he was on a near-empty Tube train on the way back towards the Docklands before he even touched his envelope. Yet all the way, he had the weirdest feeling about him, a thought constantly nagging away in his head: have I just been paid for sex?

It didn’t feel like banknotes, though, there was no thick wad of currency in there, and he assumed if anyone who used a hotel suite like that one was going to pay a guy for sex, it wouldn’t be for peanuts. But surely they wouldn’t pay with a check, or a banker’s draft or anything like that?

Just between the St Paul’s and Bank stops, he tore open the envelope.

Inside was a small piece of paper—and was it rice paper?—perhaps the size of a large postage stamp, on which were printed in regular-sized font three letters: RMZ.

He was actually fairly relieved that it wasn't money. But what on Earth was it?

And would any of this get him closer to finding the Black Widow?

A Killer of a One Night Stand In the Next Episode...

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Meanwhile, as he struggles with his feelings for his beautiful personal assistant, Emma, and the confused signals she sends his way, Jonah sees that he must not only accept that he must share her, but that it will be necessary for the investigation to have her seeing other men.

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